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For example, some roles might not seek her out once they learned she was married.

That would indeed be a loss.

But Liang Shi had never thought of hiding this matter; she simply didn't want Xu Qingzhu to be exposed to the public eye.

There was nothing to hide about her marital status.

Compared to her family, her career wasn't as important.

Liang Shi's candid response actually made everyone less interested, and the buzz quickly died down.

She had now aired two productions and was currently filming another. The roles complemented her well. Since she hadn't planned to become a top-tier celebrity, she wasn't going down that route anyway.

News of a not-so-famous actress being married wasn't considered juicy gossip¹ to netizens.

This matter happened to distract Liang Shi, and by the time she finished handling it, she realized over two hours had already passed.

Liang Shi went to pick up the results together with Xu Qingzhu.

Just like how Liang Shi had accompanied Xu Qingzhu throughout the entire process when Xu Qingzhu acknowledged Su Yao, this time Xu Qingzhu also stood firmly by her side.

To be honest, Liang Shi had imagined many possible outcomes and had even rationally thought of ways to respond to them.

The result was within expectations, yet she still found it unbelievable.

The expert opinion in the identification report stated: The probability of a biological parent-child relationship being established is 99.9999%.

In other words, she was indeed Zhu Mingqi's daughter.

After receiving the identification report, Liang Shi sat on a bench with Xu Qingzhu in a daze.

She didn't know what she was thinking about; her thoughts were simply scattered.

It took her a long while to adjust her emotions before she stood up and said to Xu Qingzhu, "Let's go."

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask what she planned to do, just quietly accompanied her.

However, after learning the results, Liang Shi still sent the news to Zhao Xuning.

Zhao Xuning only replied coldly: 【Got it.】

She had probably guessed it long ago.

Liang Shi didn't mention acknowledging her relatives; she felt it would be too abrupt.

Perhaps it was because the Shen family's relationships were currently very harmonious, and the Shen family's status was too high—she felt a sense of inferiority.

Also a sense of powerlessness.

Just like before, she was still afraid to face the unknown.

Because she didn't want to break the current balance, she chose to temporarily avoid it.

That evening, Liang Shi also fell into silence and didn't seem to be in a good mood.

Xu Qingzhu said that since she was going to struggle with it either way, she might as well just say it and let others struggle with it instead.

But Liang Shi shook her head vigorously.

Later, the two lay in bed. After the lights were turned off, Liang Shi said in a low voice, "In the past, I imagined many times what my parents would be like, what their personalities would be, whether I would have siblings. After coming here, I thought those were my parents and family, but later found out they weren't. Now I've discovered that my actual parents and family are so dazzling, but I'm so ordinary."

"Shen Fenghe has an MBA from a prestigious foreign university and also studied psychology. Shen Hui is a graduate student at a famous foreign medical school. Shen Siyan goes to Qingyi University." Liang Shi said, "I never went to university. I feel this is a regret, but it's also a regret that can't be remedied."

"I don't fit in with them, just like when I tried to integrate into your world—it took so much effort. But because it was you, I was willing to work hard, to change, to accept all the worlds around you that I might never have been exposed to, to try to understand."

"But now, I'm facing an even bigger change, and I don't want to change anymore. They're all wonderful, but I feel like I'm not from the same world as them. I don't want to compete with them for anything, nor do I want to put myself in an unfamiliar environment. It's like being naked with everyone looking at you, about to set off a new wave of commotion. I'm afraid I'll be exhausted, so I retreat."

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi murmured softly, calling Xu Qingzhu's name with tender affection, carrying a hint of bitterness, "Am I very cowardly?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu responded, then kissed her lips in the darkness. "Our Teacher Liang has been so wronged."

Like coaxing a child.

But Liang Shi chuckled softly, "I'm not wronged. At least I know they're still alive, and I wasn't the one who was abandoned."

If she had found out she was abandoned, she would probably be very sad.

She would feel like she had been abandoned by the whole world.

But now knowing that she wasn't abandoned, and that there were people at home who missed her—this was also a kind of comfort.

"So you're never going to acknowledge them?" Xu Qingzhu asked her. "Keep this secret hidden away?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "I haven't decided yet. Who knows, maybe one day on impulse I'll blurt out the secret."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "That works too."

She completely respected Liang Shi's decision.

"Just like you said, we went to verify this just to hold the initiative in our own hands." Liang Shi said, "So now we're in the dominant position."

Xu Qingzhu responded softly, "Yes."

Footnotes:

¹ "Juicy gossip" - The original Chinese uses "瓜" (guā), literally meaning "melon." In Chinese internet slang, "eating melons" (吃瓜) refers to watching drama unfold or consuming gossip as a spectator, similar to eating popcorn while watching a show. So "不算瓜" means "not considered gossip worth paying attention to."

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After seeing her own thoughts clearly, Liang Shi stopped forcing things.

Life continued on as usual.

But she still had one system task left incomplete.

To save the original host, she needed to collect all the evidence. She currently had the recording with Daoist Master Yunyin, the photos of that room she had preserved from before, including the blood-stained button from when the original host attempted self-harm, the diagnostic records obtained from the original host's psychologist, and recordings from every meeting with Qin Lishuang.

Although the Yang Jiani incident happened to her personally, it could still count as some supplementary evidence.

Liang Shi didn't want to make the original host completely innocent or anything like that—she just thought that even if they wiped her memories and let her start over, that would be good enough.

Perhaps there was a bit of evil in her nature, but her crimes didn't warrant such punishment.

Someone who had been oppressed here yet didn't become utterly wicked—just based on the fact that she chose self-harm rather than hurting others when she was extremely agitated—Liang Shi felt she deserved a chance to start over.

It was also for Grandpa and Grandma, for the lives they had exchanged.

Just like the stereotypical impression of Lu Jiayi, forming stereotypes about someone for things that hadn't even happened yet didn't seem quite right to Liang Shi.

So she made this choice.

But these weren't enough.

The most terrifying thing the original host experienced should be the evidence of Qiu Zimin's seemingly boundless pampering that was actually endless PUA¹.

She needed some testimony and physical evidence.

This was very difficult to obtain.

Although there was a recording from the previous confrontation with Qiu Zimin, it had yielded minimal results.

Liang Shi felt it was still necessary to meet with Qiu Zimin.

Now that she knew she was a daughter of the Shen family, she was also quite curious about the mystery of her own origins.

How did they manage to take her—only one month old—out from under Shi'an Hospital's ironclad security, especially when she was in a near-death state at the time?

Liang Shi was very curious.

She had previously heard from Feng Xian that she had only found her near-death self beside a garbage bin outside Shi'an Hospital.

So who threw her beside the garbage bin at Shi'an Hospital?

And who told Qiu Zimin that she could go pick her up at Shi'an Hospital?

She wouldn't believe this was a coincidence.

What normal person would go outside Shi'an Hospital to pick up a dead infant?

Liang Shi was more inclined to think this was an inside job with outside coordination.

But who could it be?

No one could tell her.

So Liang Shi still called Qiu Zimin and arranged to meet her.

Liang Shi arranged to meet Qiu Zimin at a Japanese restaurant.

Purely because the private rooms at Japanese restaurants were more suitable for two people to discuss matters.

Meeting with Qiu Zimin couldn't possibly be a pleasant experience, and she wouldn't be able to eat anyway, so Liang Shi had prepared in advance and eaten a meal before going to see Qiu Zimin.

When she arrived at the agreed location, Qiu Zimin hadn't arrived yet. Liang Shi played on her phone in the private room for a while before Qiu Zimin finally showed up late, her expression still cold, her eyes filled with disgust.

But Liang Shi wasn't sure if it was her imagination—she always felt there was a sickly pallor on Qiu Zimin's face, a sickly look that even blush couldn't conceal.

"What do you want?" Qiu Zimin's tone was aggressive from the start. "What is there left to say between us?"

Liang Shi lowered her eyes and poured her a cup of tea. "I've recently discovered some things, so there should still be something to discuss."

"What are you being so mysterious about?" Qiu Zimin frowned slightly. "Just say it directly. I have things to attend to."

"Are you enjoying getting along with your biological daughter?" Liang Shi asked.

Qiu Zimin's brow furrowed into a little mountain. "What does that have to do with you? What's wrong? Are you still trying to find your biological parents?"

"Not anymore." Liang Shi said. "Why would I bother?"

Qiu Zimin let out a cold laugh, seeming to mock her for overestimating herself.

But Liang Shi didn't take her attitude to heart and said in a gentle voice, "I recently looked into someone called Shen Chi."

The moment this name came out, Qiu Zimin's expression changed.

"What are you trying to do?!" Qiu Zimin said harshly. "Who gave you the audacity to investigate me?"

"It was just a casual investigation. Does that require audacity?" Liang Shi curved her lips into a light smile. "Why can't I investigate you? I need to know why you've been treating me like you're crazy, don't I?"

"What are you talking about? I don't understand." Qiu Zimin played dumb.

"How could you not understand?" Liang Shi's voice grew cold. "I'm talking about things you've done—like secretly decorating my room into a haunted house without anyone knowing, ordering custom-made creepy sculptures with broken arms for me, constantly using PUA to suppress me and turn me into a useless person, and also sending me to Qin Lishuang to be her human model. Do you know how many times Qin Lishuang whipped me that day? A full twelve lashes."

"Oh right, you also sent me to Yang Jiani. Yang Jiani killed her own daughter with her own hands, and now she's suffered the consequences—did you know? She killed herself. What about you? Don't you need to pay the price for what you've done?"

Liang Shi had excellent delivery skills. When she said these words, they were both stern and slow, unhurried as they came out, unconsciously creating a sense of pressure.

In that moment, Qiu Zimin stared into her eyes and shrank back slightly.

It was as if she saw Zhu Mingqi in her prime from many years ago.

Qiu Zimin retreated a bit, her hand propping herself on the ground, still forcing herself to hold on. "What nonsense are you spouting? I raised you this big—even if I have no merit, I at least worked hard, right? How can you not remember any of it? And now you're turning around to bite me! Even a dog wouldn't do this!"

Although she was scolding, there was no real intimidation in it.

Liang Shi wasn't afraid.

Footnotes:

¹ PUA - Originally stands for "Pick-Up Artist," but in Chinese internet culture, it has evolved to mean psychological manipulation or emotional abuse tactics used to control someone, breaking down their self-esteem and making them dependent on the manipulator.

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"You know exactly what you've done all these years." Liang Shi said. "I have evidence of everything. Do you want Big Brother and the others to find out? Big Brother went to Qin Lishuang's place before."

"Oh right." Liang Shi added. "Gu Xingyue—the replacement Qi Jiao from before—gave me a USB drive. The USB drive has videos of Yang Jiani beating us. Do you want to see them?"

"You lunatic!" Qiu Zimin stood up, but stumbled the moment she rose. If she hadn't steadied herself against the wall, she would have fallen back to the ground.

Liang Shi curved her lips. "If I really am crazy, then it's because you drove me crazy. You've always oppressed me into doing things in the name of love, and I listened to everything. I thought things would get better if I listened to you, but what happened? You intensified your efforts and persecuted me behind everyone's backs. If I hadn't endured it, I would definitely be dead."

As Liang Shi spoke, she raised her head and stared at her fiercely. "You know what I'm talking about."

Qiu Zimin clutched her handbag and staggered toward the door, still forcing herself to hold on, but it was clear that her psychological defenses were on the verge of collapse.

After her agitated questioning, Liang Shi slowed her speech and relaxed her voice. "Whether you admit it or not, I know where I came from, and I know why you treated me this way."

Qiu Zimin continued walking toward the exit, having already pulled open the door.

Liang Shi's voice rang out in the private room: "It's because of Shen Chi, isn't it?"

"A brief romance with Shen Chi, only to discover that Shen Chi loved someone else. Later, when Shen Chi became seriously ill and went abroad alone, she was the only one she didn't tell where she was going. So you were jealous, unwilling, and filled with hatred. You hated Shen Chi's white moonlight¹." Liang Shi let out a low laugh at this point and continued, "So after your daughter was gone, you colluded with someone to steal me out of Shi'an Hospital, switching me in her place."

Qiu Zimin's footsteps halted. She slammed the door shut with a clatter and turned back to question her: "How do you know?"

Liang Shi smiled lightly. "Because you don't like my mother, that's why you treated me this way. Constantly tormenting me, constantly ■■■ me², yet also trapping me in a strange cycle of love—this was your way of taking revenge on my mother for Shen Chi's sake, wasn't it?"

"You..." Qiu Zimin suddenly paused, becoming alert. "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

Liang Shi hadn't expected her psychological defenses to be so strong, still able to stubbornly resist even after Shen Chi and Zhu Mingqi were brought up.

Liang Shi felt a brief moment of panic in her heart, but quickly overcame it.

She stared at Qiu Zimin. "What's there to deny? Everything I've said is the truth."

"What are you trying to prove with recordings?" Qiu Zimin looked at her. "That I'm a bad woman? That I'm a bad mother?"

"Liang Shi! I really raised you for nothing all these years!" Qiu Zimin continued to accuse her. "Your father still wanted me to keep you in the Liang family. Good thing I didn't do that, otherwise the Liang family would definitely be the ones suffering now!"

"My father? You mean Liang Zu?" Liang Shi laughed lightly. "Does he know how good you are at deceiving people? Does he know he's living in a lie? You deceived him, saying my fortune could be exchanged with the Liang family's, so you decorated my room like that."

Qiu Zimin's face showed terror, but she couldn't bring herself to speak for a long time.

"I'm not recording." Liang Shi smiled. "Why bother? You won't say anything anyway."

"I just wanted to verify things with you, that's all."

Qiu Zimin hesitated, clearly not believing her.

But Liang Shi had no intention of continuing to tangle with her. "Now that I know who my biological parents are, and I know why you treated me this way, I can only say—Shen Chi was right not to love you back then."

"What did you say?!" Qiu Zimin suddenly went mad, her eyes crimson red. She raised her hand to hit Liang Shi, but Liang Shi was quick to block her. Liang Shi continued to provoke her: "Was I wrong?"

Qiu Zimin glared at her with gritted teeth, and a tear fell. "As expected of Zhu Mingqi's daughter—just as cheap as her!"

"Heh." Liang Shi taunted. "But Shen Chi still didn't choose you."

"You're talking nonsense! Shen Chi was just deceived by your mother... pfft..." Before Qiu Zimin could finish, she suddenly spat out a mouthful of blood. The dark circles under her eyes couldn't be concealed anymore. She raised her hand to cover her mouth, her whole body swaying unsteadily.

Liang Shi released her grip on Qiu Zimin's wrist, and Qiu Zimin leaned against the wall.

"You..." Liang Shi hesitated.

Qiu Zimin raised her hand to wipe the blood from the corner of her mouth. "Spare me your fake sympathy."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, momentarily speechless.

Qiu Zimin gave her a disgusted look. "I should have strangled you to death back then."

Her tone was sinister.

Anyone who heard it would not doubt the truthfulness of her words.

After she left, Liang Shi sat there, poured out the tea from her cup, refilled it, and took a sip.

The tea hadn't steeped properly and was slightly bitter.

After her thoughts settled, she stood up and removed the pinhole camera she had installed on the wall.

Everything just now had been recorded—all of Qiu Zimin's expressions and all her moments of madness.

Liang Shi let out a heavy sigh, releasing all the pent-up frustration in her chest.

【Ding dong! Does the host need something from me? I have good news to tell you—the original host's danger level has been reduced to S-rank, which is better than before!】

【However, it still doesn't meet the release standard. Of course, if the host can gather all the evidence properly, Little System will definitely put in a good word for the original host at the Interstellar Court!】

Liang Shi: "..."

She had finally managed to summon the system, only to feel irritated the moment she heard that grating mechanical voice.

But irritated as she was, she still needed to communicate what needed to be communicated.

"I've finished collecting all the evidence." Liang Shi said. "I've found the reason why Qiu Zimin treated the original host this way, and I've also found all the video and audio materials of everything that hurt the original host before. Do you want to copy them or take the originals?"

The system was silent for two seconds: 【Copying is fine~】

That sickeningly sweet tone again.

Liang Shi put all the evidence onto a USB drive. She didn't know how the system would copy it.

Anyway, two minutes later, that mechanical voice sounded: 【Copying complete.】

Liang Shi's USB drive hadn't been touched at all.

Afterward, the system said it would report the progress of this matter to her and would strive to give the original host a chance at rebirth.

After saying all this, Liang Shi suddenly asked: 【Why do you punish the original host instead of punishing people like Qiu Zimin?】

The system was silent for a moment.

While thinking about how to answer this question, it suddenly remembered that it had told her once before.

It was just that because it involved certain unspeakable matters, her memory had been erased when she was transmitted back to this world.

Now Liang Shi was asking this question again.

Footnotes:

¹ White moonlight (白月光) - A Chinese internet slang term referring to someone's first love or an unforgettable, idealized love interest who remains in one's heart. The term evokes the image of pure, untouchable moonlight—beautiful but unreachable.

² The "■■■" symbols represent censored content in the original text, likely referring to abusive actions that were redacted by the publishing platform.

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After thinking, the system answered in a way humans could understand: 【Because someone's voice was heard by the gods, the gods granted you fortune, but also brought you misfortune. Everyone is subject to the laws and regulations within their dimensional world, but only those who have been chosen are subject to interstellar constraints.】

Liang Shi: "..."

So she and the original host were the humans whose voices had been heard by the gods.

Indeed.

She had once wished for lots and lots of love.

Then what about the original host?

Lots and lots of money?

This was just Liang Shi's guess.

With the mindset that she wouldn't have anything to do with the system after this matter was resolved, Liang Shi asked the system directly: "Can you tell me what voices of ours were heard by the gods?"

At this point, the system no longer concealed anything and transmitted a sequence of images into her mind.

The images contained not only her childhood, not only the wishes she made every year.

There was also another person's childhood.

That person had the same face as her. Her father was mute, and her mother had a long scar on her face, so she always wore a veil to cover it.

They were the poorest family in the village, and she was always mocked at school for dressing plainly and living in the worst house in the village.

Her greatest wish was to have money and to live in a new house.

When she learned that she could make wishes on her birthday, she made several wishes.

"I hope Dad can speak."

"I hope Mom's face gets better."

"I hope Grandpa's legs don't hurt on rainy days."

"I hope Grandma doesn't have to work so hard."

In her seventh year, her parents went out shopping on her birthday, only to tragically encounter a car accident.

She became an orphan from then on.

Her status as an orphan didn't earn her any special treatment either—she was still the isolated one in class.

She would go to school on time and return home on time with her backpack after school.

But on the way, she would hear people calling her: "Jinx! Bad luck charm!"¹

Her family received 200,000 yuan in compensation from her parents' car accident.

On the day she couldn't help but get into a fight with her classmates, her grandparents discussed moving away.

They moved to another village closer to town and built a new house.

And in her eighth year, she made a wish while crying in front of birthday candles.

She said: "I want lots and lots of money."

And so, her wish was heard by the gods.

She and she exchanged places.

One received money, one received love.

And all their terrible memories from before were erased, allowing them to start anew.

This was the gods' favor to them.

But little did they know, it was also the beginning of other nightmares.

This was the original host's story.

When Liang Shi watched this sequence of images, her eyes welled up with tears several times.

After watching, her entire heart felt like something was stuffed inside it—an aching, tingling soreness.

Liang Shi asked the system with a choked voice: 【So why was it us? Life was already hard enough.】

The system was silent for a moment. Liang Shi wasn't sure if it was her imagination, but that mechanical voice seemed to carry a hint of human hesitation at this moment: 【Many things have no why. It can only be said that it's you.】

Just like how people always wonder: Why me?

Why did things turn out this way?

Why is my life so terrible?

Why can't I have both money and love?

Why do I have to suffer so much?

So often, the most powerless feeling comes from: there is no why.

Because it's your life.

Some people's lives shine brightly, but some people never have a single ray of light shine into their entire lives.

The original host's life was like this, and Liang Shi's life nearly was too.

Fortunately, they were working hard.

Working hard to run toward the distance.

Working hard to let the light in.

Since they were powerless to ask why, they could only struggle to change themselves.

That night when Liang Shi went to sleep holding Xu Qingzhu, she suddenly said with deep emotion: "Thank you."

Xu Qingzhu was confused and touched her face. "What's wrong with my Teacher Liang now? Looking so pitiful, and even crying."

Xu Qingzhu leaned in and kissed her. "Did you watch some TV drama again?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "It's more tragic than any TV drama."

She thought for a moment and still told Xu Qingzhu about the original host's story.

Because although she had never met the parents from that side, from their photos together, they seemed like two very kind people, just like her grandpa and grandma.

If they were still alive, they would have given Liang Shi lots of love too.

Xu Qingzhu was also silent for a while after hearing this.

Liang Shi hugged her, feeling aggrieved and pitiful. "So that's why I want to thank you. You're the one who let light shine into my life."

But Xu Qingzhu lay flat, her fingers sliding between Liang Shi's fingers, interlocking with hers. "That's not true. You took care of me first."

Xu Qingzhu said: "If it weren't for you back then, I might have died in that kidnapping case."

Liang Shi paused briefly. "Speaking of which, I should also thank Qi Jiao. If it weren't for her, I wouldn't have been so strong either."

But speaking of Qi Jiao was another sad matter.

Liang Shi placed her hand on Xu Qingzhu's belly, as if covering the ears of the two little ones.

Liang Shi's voice was soft yet gentle as she said: "These things are more like snow falling on the world—each person has their own shadows and brightness."

Yang Jiani was like that, yet she raised a little angel like Qi Jiao.

And Qi Jiao was gentle and beautiful, so she met Chen Mian, who came to bring her light.

But Chen Mian didn't get to wait for her Qi Jiao to grow up.

Qi Jiao, who didn't get to grow up, went to another place. Living here in her place, enduring silently, was Gu Xingyue—stolen by human traffickers but then abandoned at an orphanage's doorstep.

The Gao family, whose family was destroyed because of the human traffickers, met with ruin—and Gu Xingyue killed her enemies with her own hands.

The original host attracted Zhou Yi'an, but because of this world's rules about Alphas not being able to be with other Alphas, or other reasons, they didn't end up together.

Zhou Yi'an kept chasing, but the original host's love for Xu Qingzhu turned to hatred, ultimately creating a tragedy.

The book followed its main plotline, while the people outside the main plot were also simultaneously experiencing their own lives.

Their joys and sorrows, loves and hatreds were all happening at the same time.

Footnotes:

¹ "Jinx! Bad luck charm!" - The original Chinese uses "災星" (zāixīng, disaster star) and "掃把星" (sàobǎxīng, broom star/comet). In Chinese folk belief, comets were considered bad omens, and people believed to bring bad luck to those around them were called these names. It's a cruel superstition often directed at orphans, implying they caused their parents' deaths.

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Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes, cause and effect, the cycle of karma—sometimes you have no choice but to believe in fate."

Liang Shi chuckled softly. "That's true."

The two sighed with emotion for quite a while longer, then Liang Shi pulled out a book from the drawer and read a story to Xu Qingzhu.

"The stars we see with our naked eyes may have exploded and died billions of years ago. At this moment, their light reaching my pupils is the most mysterious coincidence..."

"Baby." Xu Qingzhu suddenly interrupted her. Her eyes were gently closed, her voice cool yet her tone gentle. "Do you think there's anything else on the Little Prince's planet besides the rose and the fox?"

"There should be a castle and a king too." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu paused briefly. "Is the Little Prince's planet farther from us, or is your planet farther from us?"

Liang Shi said, "I don't know."

"Are there people on all the stars we can see with our naked eyes?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Like on the planet where you came from."

Liang Shi still shook her head. "I don't know, but there should be dimensional worlds that exist."

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingzhu said. "You mean time is progressing simultaneously in many places, and in another place there are people like us who also have their own lives, is that it?"

"More or less." Liang Shi said. "Just like on my planet and here."

"Are we humans being controlled?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Like you and that person, being switched around at will."

"No, we're being controlled, but also not being controlled. They manipulate us according to our wishes."

"..."

Before falling asleep, the two were both thinking about strange, vast questions, and even their dreams were of endless galaxies and the universe.

The next day when they woke up, Liang Shi said she dreamed of a spaceship, and Xu Qingzhu said she dreamed of planting roses on a barren planet.

Both exclaimed how absurd their dreams were.

Once they talked it out, things actually felt better.

Having someone to listen to her boredom and worries meant Liang Shi wouldn't keep everything bottled up inside.

Many things don't seem like such a big deal once you say them out loud.

So Liang Shi didn't feel sad about the original host for too long. She only hoped that the original host could have a brand new life after going through all these things.

Time flew by, and soon it was late spring.

Yu Wan's baby had already had their one-month celebration banquet¹, and Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui had finally reconciled completely.

Zhao Xuning still hadn't told Shen Hui about the Wu Li matter.

She only said she had regretted it that day, so she went to confess.

Shen Hui didn't ask further.

When Liang Shi went to visit Yu Wan, she happened to learn that Qiu Zimin had fallen ill and was hospitalized—apparently it was quite serious.

Liang Shi didn't think about going to visit her.

Guo Xinran was still active on screen and had even taken on a TV drama, starting off with an S+ production right away.

Liang Shi wasn't envious of her; she just felt the power of capital was too strong.

When she complained to Xu Qingzhu about it, Xu Qingzhu laughed and teased her: "What? Do you also want me to help you?"

Liang Shi pinched her waist. "What kind of person do you think I am?"

"My person." Xu Qingzhu said matter-of-factly. "I want to give to you, so I give to you. I'm willing."

"I'm not willing." Liang Shi said. "I want to stick to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

It was also because Xu Qingzhu's belly was getting bigger and bigger. When she was in the early months it wasn't obvious, but now that she was further along, the twin pregnancy was very apparent—Xu Qingzhu's belly was huge.

Now every day Liang Shi had to help apply cream to Xu Qingzhu's belly to prevent loose skin after giving birth.

Liang Shi felt heartache just looking at it and kept saying why couldn't they just adopt two? Why did she have to give birth herself?

Of course, her words didn't make any difference.

In everyone's view, Omegas getting pregnant and giving birth was normal.

Especially since the birth rate on this planet was so low that abortion was no longer allowed.

Since Xu Qingzhu found it inconvenient to travel now, Liang Shi drove her everywhere every day.

She didn't spend much time on set, so she found something else to do—she started filming Vlogs.

Her Vlogs weren't about herself but were themed.

Each episode was very short, like a mini documentary about a profession.

Her first episode featured the security guards of their residential complex and the neighboring complex.

All these Vlogs were filmed in her spare time. She started learning camera work, photography, editing, and even lighting on her own.

After filming three episodes, Gu Yixue took the initiative to message her: 【Like.jpg】

But Liang Shi didn't hold back: 【Where's your new script?】

Gu Yixue: 【...No ideas. Planning to adapt an IP²】

Liang Shi: 【?】

Liang Shi: 【A movie?】

Gu Yixue: 【TV drama. Should be a 12-episode short series. There's a web novel that was really popular a while ago called "Sharp Edge"—have you read it?】

Liang Shi: 【No, I haven't even heard of it.】

Gu Yixue: 【The platform is inviting me to film this now. They're offering quite a bit of money.】

Liang Shi: 【Since when do you care about money?】

Gu Yixue: 【...The novel is pretty good.】

Liang Shi felt this was her honest opinion.

For someone like Gu Yixue, money was secondary—content was what mattered most.

But Gu Yixue still had concerns. Collaborating with a platform was different from before. Having a platform meant having investors. When Gu Yixue filmed works before, it was her one-woman show. Even if investors wanted to insert someone, they had to see if Gu Yixue agreed.

If Gu Yixue said no, the investors wouldn't dare push it.

If they really made Gu Yixue angry, then the investors could take their money and get lost—Gu Yixue wasn't short on money.

If she signed with the platform, it would mean Gu Yixue couldn't do as she pleased.

Yet the novel's copyright was with the platform, and the platform had promised Gu Yixue absolute authority.

They even gave her the rights to adapt the script.

This made Gu Yixue somewhat tempted.

Liang Shi suggested she take it. She could try collaborating with others. Before, when she was alone abroad, having her own team was enough. Now that she was back in the country, she would inevitably face restrictions everywhere—she might as well lean on a big tree for shade³.

But Gu Yixue told her to read it first. If there was an opportunity, they could collaborate on another project. She thought there was a role in it that would suit Liang Shi well.

Liang Shi: "..."

Was this the benefit of having powerful friends?

Still, Liang Shi did order the book online.

She noticed the author's pen name was "Wenchuan."

She felt like she'd seen this name somewhere before.

Footnotes:

¹ One-month celebration banquet (滿月酒) - A traditional Chinese celebration held when a baby turns one month old. It's an important milestone as infant mortality was historically high in the first month, so surviving meant the baby was strong enough to celebrate. Family and friends gather for a feast to celebrate the baby's health.

² IP - Stands for "Intellectual Property." In the Chinese entertainment industry, "IP adaptation" refers to adapting existing intellectual properties like popular novels, comics, or games into TV dramas or films.

³ "Lean on a big tree for shade" (背靠大樹好乘涼) - A Chinese proverb meaning it's beneficial to have powerful backing or support. Just as standing under a big tree provides shade from the sun, having a powerful ally or organization behind you makes things easier.

Chapter 177-6

Liang Shi's Vlogs were also flourishing. She had even found some joy in directing, and in her spare time, she would often exchange insights with Gu Yixue.

Life was gradually becoming interesting and vibrant.

Lu Jiayi and Fu You's wedding was scheduled for late spring, to be held in the Capital¹.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu even flew to the Capital for it.

The Lu family was considered a prestigious family in the Capital, and the Fu family was not to be underestimated either. It was just that Fu You's status wasn't quite so illustrious.

Fu You's mother was not Madam Fu, and she wasn't even part of the Fu family.

At the wedding, Xu Qingzhu found a spot to sit and bask in the sun while listening to people gossip. They said Fu You's mother had become a nun.

Because back then, Fu You's father had married the current Madam Fu, while Fu You's mother had unknowingly become the other woman.

But others said that Fu You's mother was her father's first love, so Fu You was her father's favorite child, treated much better than the children Madam Fu had given birth to.

However, even Mr. Fu's reach had its limits. He was constantly away on business trips and busy with company matters, so he didn't pay that much attention to Fu You either.

But this wedding was indeed lavishly held.

The best location in the Capital, the most luxurious restaurant, hosting a continuous banquet² with nearly a thousand guests coming and going.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu even privately discussed which family was richer—the Lu family of the Capital or the Shen family of Haizhou.

In the end, they concluded that the Lu family of the Capital had more power, while the Shen family of Haizhou had more money.

The two of them were just like ordinary wives, casually discussing high-society gossip.

This wedding gave Liang Shi quite a shock, making her start planning something in her heart.

When the time came, their wedding should be held by the sea.

Liang Shi wanted to go to the seaside, to send the festivities off to a more distant place.

Liang Shi had never been to the Capital here before, so she took this opportunity to explore the Capital with Xu Qingzhu.

Since the two of them were from Haizhou, Lu Jiayi and Fu You even came to volunteer as their tour guides the day after the wedding was done.

Liang Shi paid particular attention to observing Lu Jiayi.

She noticed that although Lu Jiayi didn't like Fu You, after marriage she was especially tolerant and caring toward Fu You. This care wasn't the kind you'd give to a girl weaker than yourself, but the thoughtfulness you'd show a wife.

Even when Fu You was being somewhat unreasonable, Lu Jiayi would frown first but then still go along with her.

What showed in her eyes wasn't someone compromising for the sake of family business and inheritance rights—it was simply that she disliked certain things, yet she would still accompany Fu You.

Liang Shi suddenly understood the post-marriage state between her and Xu Qingzhu that was described in the original text.

Because Lu Jiayi was just this kind of person.

No matter who she married, once she decided, even if she had to pretend, she could put on the appearance of a good wife.

And she and Xu Qingzhu were such soulmates—the two of them had many things they liked together and could chat well together. Even without romantic love, they could live quite well.

But with Fu You, it was obvious that Lu Jiayi got angry more frequently.

Fu You often tested the dangerous boundaries, yet she never truly made Lu Jiayi angry.

On the night before Liang Shi and the others left the Capital, Lu Jiayi invited them to drink at a club.

It was one of those high-end, proper clubs.

Fu You didn't come.

She said she was attending a classmate reunion and would come over after it ended.

Lu Jiayi fulfilled her duties as a host quite well, but when chatting, she and Xu Qingzhu still couldn't escape business topics.

Although Lu Jiayi was eighty percent confident she would obtain the Lu family's inheritance rights, she had also made two backup plans for herself.

One was to go to Haizhou and start her own business, leaving the Capital for good.

The other was to expand the family business after obtaining the inheritance rights, which would also require Haizhou.

So she had a lot to say to Xu Qingzhu at the moment, and the business ambitions the two were envisioning were indeed grand.

So grand that if Liang Shi didn't know what kind of people these two were, she would have thought they'd drunk several bottles of erguotou³ before they could brag like this.

Around eleven o'clock, Xu Qingzhu was getting sleepy.

Just as they stood up to leave, Fu You finally showed up late, reeking of alcohol.

As soon as she entered, she looked for Lu Jiayi. After Lu Jiayi steadied her, Fu You asked pitifully and aggrieved: "Am I pretty?"

Lu Jiayi: "..."

Lu Jiayi wasn't good at saying these kinds of things—she was like a completely different person from when she was discussing business ambitions with Xu Qingzhu.

But Fu You straightened her shoulders: "Lu Jiayi, are you going to answer or not?"

Lu Jiayi: "...Let's go home."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't want to be third wheels anymore, so they said their goodbyes and headed out.

They could hear the argument continuing behind them.

"You won't even compliment my looks? Lu Jiayi, are you blind?"

"Lu Jiayi, do you believe I'll break your legs?"

"Lu Jiayi, carry me."

Later, when Liang Shi was helping Xu Qingzhu into the car, she saw Lu Jiayi emerge from the club carrying the drunk Fu You on her back.

Liang Shi gave her a thumbs up.

Lu Jiayi's expression was a mix of helplessness and amusement.

But when she was carrying Fu You into the car, she was particularly careful and attentive.

A person like that—even without love, you could probably spend a lifetime with her.

Liang Shi suddenly sighed with emotion, "Lu Jiayi really is a good person."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Gu Yixue really did sign a contract with the platform, and just like that, the S+ rated project was handed over to Gu Yixue.

Meanwhile, the Vlogs Liang Shi posted on Weibo also generated a huge response.

Everyone said her Vlogs were shot like documentaries, and many urged her to switch careers and become a director.

Liang Shi didn't lose herself over it, but she did start having thoughts about transitioning from in front of the camera to behind it.

Being in front of the camera only required thinking about herself, but being behind the scenes required multiple considerations—coordination between actors, from initial casting and team organization to later publicity and distribution—all required considerable effort.

Liang Shi felt that being an actress still suited her better for now.

She also squeezed out time to finish reading the novel "Sharp Edge."

It was somewhat dark, but it was definitely the style Gu Yixue liked. Especially the ending—just imagining it, you could picture that sharp aesthetic.

This kind of shot could probably only be filmed by Gu Yixue.

But "Sharp Edge" always gave Liang Shi a sense of déjà vu, a feeling of oppression, as if someone she knew had been written into the book and persecuted.

When she exchanged thoughts with Gu Yixue, Gu Yixue said this was what made this writer remarkable.

Being able to effortlessly draw people into the story.

That's why it made you feel suffocated.

Reading this work felt like drowning in water. Just when you were about to run out of breath, someone would pull you up. Just when you thought you were saved, they would drown you again.

Over and over.

Every single time.

Carrying a beauty on the verge of suffocation.

Liang Shi also began to admire this author called "Wenchuan."

Gu Yixue said she would try to work on the script with this author, and would also try to invite this author to be an on-set screenwriter. The adaptation would be done while respecting the original work as much as possible.

Afterward, Gu Yixue's conversations with Wenchuan went very smoothly, and even the process of writing the script together was incredibly smooth.

In Gu Yixue's words, she had never written a script this smoothly before.

She even felt that creating together with someone else was much more comfortable than creating alone.

Both were very satisfied with the script.

This was probably the mutual appreciation between creators.

Most importantly, both of them understood the core of that story, so the process of expanding on that core was very smooth.

Footnotes:

¹ Capital (京都, Jīngdū) - In this novel, "Jingdu" refers to the capital city of the fictional world, similar to Beijing in our world. It literally means "Capital City."

² Continuous banquet (流水宴, liúshuǐ yàn) - A style of banquet where food is continuously served and guests come and go in waves rather than sitting down for a single meal together. This is common for very large celebrations like weddings where there are too many guests to accommodate at once.

³ Erguotou (二鍋頭) - A strong Chinese grain alcohol (baijiu) typically around 50-60% ABV. It's known as a working-class drink and is relatively cheap. The joke here is that only someone very drunk would make such grandiose claims—but since these are actually wealthy businesswomen, their ambitions are real.

Chapter 177-7

After the script passed review, Gu Yixue quickly assembled her team, preparing to enter a new round of casting and filming.

Apart from the role Gu Yixue planned to save for Liang Shi, the rest would be cast through open auditions.

But unexpectedly, as soon as the news of "Sharp Edge" being adapted for screen came out, the book fans exploded, pushing several hashtags onto the trending searches.

[Frankly speaking, are there no screenwriters left in the entertainment industry?]

[I don't want to see "Sharp Edge" made into a drama. No one can play the Qiao Wenyu in my heart, and no one can play my Jiao-jie either.]

[No matter who it is, they can't film it well. Don't ruin the book.]

[I'm just curious about one thing—even if this drama gets filmed, can it pass censorship?]

[...]

Indeed, "Sharp Edge" touched on many social issues.

Such as child trafficking, such as domestic violence, such as the absence of law at the family level.

But it was precisely because of this that Gu Yixue was even more interested.

It was also the reason everyone loved this novel.

Dark enough, and thrilling enough.

The suspense was maxed out, and so were the emotions.

As long as it was filmed well, it would definitely be a hit.

Gu Yixue didn't care what the book fans said—she never read online comments anyway.

It wasn't until someone said Gu Yixue was directing and the original author Wenchuan was serving as screenwriter that the book fans' uproar finally calmed down a bit.

When casting was halfway done, Gu Yixue suddenly sent Liang Shi a message one day: 【How unlucky.】

At that moment, Liang Shi had just finished packing up her camera and was about to go out to film a Vlog about sanitation workers.

Liang Shi replied with confusion: 【?】

Gu Yixue: 【The platform wants to insert someone.】

Liang Shi understood instantly: 【Sharp Edge?】

Gu Yixue: 【Guess who they want to insert?】

Liang Shi: 【No idea.】

Gu Yixue: 【Guo Xinran.】

Liang Shi: 【...】

That really was unpleasant news.

Gu Yixue complained: 【The last movie already made me very unhappy. Are they crazy?】

Liang Shi: 【So what did you say?】

Gu Yixue: 【Refused.】

Liang Shi replied that she had backbone, then went out to film her Vlog.

After she finished filming and picked up Xu Qingzhu from work, she found that Gu Yixue had sent her a message: 【This role was saved for you.】

Liang Shi: 【?】

Liang Shi: 【It's fine if I don't act in it.】

Liang Shi: 【You deal with that side first.】

Most importantly, Liang Shi didn't want to fight.

Going up against Guo Xinran would inevitably mean going up against the Liang family and Qiu Zimin.

It really put her in a bad mood.

But Gu Yixue replied: 【The original author thinks so too. The role of Qiao Wenyu can only be played by you.】

Liang Shi: 【...Alright.】

At the same time, Gu Yixue sent her the script for "Sharp Edge."

A twelve-episode script in total. The volume wasn't large, but the content was very substantial. The structure of each episode was arranged very tightly, and not a single character had a wasted line.

While Liang Shi was reading the script, Gu Yixue had already gone to fight with the platform people.

She sat in a chair in her room, playing with a silver lighter in her hand. Her phone was on speaker, placed on her lap. She casually reached for the pack of cigarettes on the table, her slender fingers pulling out a cigarette and placing it between her lips.

Her red lips held the cigarette, her long hair cascading loosely over her shoulders—anyone who saw her would think she was full of allure.

She was still wearing a tight cropped top, her waistline exposed, looking very beautiful.

She brought the silver lighter close to the cigarette, lit it carelessly, then exhaled a puff of smoke, her voice cold: "The lead has been decided. Go insert your people into other productions."

"Director Quella, this person is really very suitable. Do you remember the video about that girl searching for her parents? Even official media reported on it." The platform's person in charge said. "She's a copy of Qiao Wenyu. Choosing her definitely won't be wrong. She also has the highest public support online right now."

"So what?" Gu Yixue scoffed. "When I agreed to collaborate with you, I already said everything would be decided by me. Whether it's the platform or the investors, don't interfere with my choices, understand?"

"Director Quella." The other party, a grown man, actually started wheedling disgustingly. "Haven't we stayed out of everything else? This is your film—you direct it, we won't say a word. But Guo Xinran is definitely suitable. Trust me."

"Bullshit." Gu Yixue sneered. "Are you directing or am I? I told you I've already chosen someone. Do you not understand?!"

The other party was silent for two seconds. "The money this time is from Dongheng—a hundred million. It doesn't make sense not to use Guo Xinran as the female lead. Director Quella, we're all in this industry, so you should understand—sometimes sentiment isn't that important, don't you think?"

"I said no, and I mean no." Gu Yixue's attitude was firm. "Nobody is inserting anyone into my crew."

The other party was momentarily speechless, not knowing how to persuade Gu Yixue.

After a moment, the other party's tone became slightly harder: "Their attitude now is that you have to use this female lead whether you want to or not. If you don't, then don't start filming."

"Tell them to withdraw their investment." Gu Yixue said. "They can take their money and their person and get lost. I can still start filming on that day, and I can still finish it."

The other party: "..."

"A hundred million." The other party frowned. "Quella, where are you going to get that much money?"

Gu Yixue: "None of your business. I filmed so many productions before they ever invested. Where do they get off?"

The other party was rendered speechless and hung up the phone in a huff.

Chapter 177-8

Gu Yixue had just finished one cigarette. She glanced at the screen that had returned to the home page, turned off her phone, tossed it aside, then took another deep drag on the cigarette. Only when the cigarette butt was about to burn her hand did she pull back, stubbing it out on the table before throwing it into the trash can. She buried herself wearily in the large chair.

After a while, the more she thought about it, the more irritated she became. She reached for the cigarettes on the table again, but just as she pulled one out, a hand pressed down on hers, stopping her from taking the cigarette.

A familiar warmth came from the back of her hand. Gu Yixue's movements froze. She slowly turned her head to look and saw Shen Fenghe standing there in a suit, backlit like a deity.

Gu Yixue was momentarily dazed.

Shen Fenghe stuffed the cigarette back into the pack, then tossed the pack aside. She loosened her tie and threw the constraining tie onto the large bed behind her, asking coldly: "Short on money?"

Only then did Gu Yixue come back to her senses. Her expression was languid, carrying a hint of grievance: "When did you get back?"

But Shen Fenghe grabbed her wrist. "I'm asking you."

"I'm also asking you." Gu Yixue stood up, very close to her.

She wasn't as tall as Shen Fenghe, so she tilted her head up slightly to look at her.

"When you were smoking your first cigarette." Shen Fenghe said.

Gu Yixue lightly pressed her lips together. The edges of her red lips were slightly smudged, the lip line blurred, her tone helpless: "Fine, you saw everything."

"When did you learn these things?" Shen Fenghe asked.

Gu Yixue leaned in closer, very close to her. "When you weren't paying attention."

"Are you short on money?" Shen Fenghe asked again.

"You heard everything and you're still asking me?" Gu Yixue smiled at her alluringly, raising an eyebrow: "Jiejie¹, shouldn't you just throw money at me directly?"

"You're not short on money." Shen Fenghe said. "You have seven hundred million in your account."

Gu Yixue: "..."

She secretly gritted her teeth. "Just because I'm not short on money, you can't give me some?"

Shen Fenghe remained unmoved, but her throat moved slightly.

"Wife." Gu Yixue's eyes reddened again. Her fingers played with the collar of Shen Fenghe's shirt, undoing the topmost button to reveal her beautiful collarbones. She called out in a charming and tender voice: "Jiejie."

But Shen Fenghe gripped her hand, calling her name with a dangerous tone, enunciating each word: "Gu. Yi. Xue."

Gu Yixue had heard this dangerous tone from her many times and didn't mind it. She was even vaguely expectant: "Hmm?"

"Stop messing around." Shen Fenghe said.

Gu Yixue leaned in and kissed her chin: "Did you drink?"

"Had a business dinner tonight." Shen Fenghe raised her arm and hugged her briefly. Her arm happened to cover the exposed waistline, the hem of her shirt sleeve overlapping with Gu Yixue's pants. "You smell like smoke."

Gu Yixue laughed softly: "You reek of smoke and alcohol yourself. How can you still smell the smoke in my mouth?"

Shen Fenghe held her and lifted her up slightly, the two of them drawing even closer. "Smoke less in the future."

"Are you worried about me?" Gu Yixue pushed her luck.

Shen Fenghe frowned slightly. "It's too pungent."

Gu Yixue pressed her lips together and withdrew from her embrace. "Forget it then."

She then returned to the chair, curling up in it again with a languid posture.

Shen Fenghe, whose arms were suddenly empty, felt momentarily out of sorts, not knowing what she should do. She also felt a chill.

She stared at Gu Yixue's profile for a while, then went straight to the bathroom to wash up, leaving Gu Yixue alone.

Only after hearing the sounds did Gu Yixue open her eyes. Looking at the myriad of lights as bright as day, she sighed at how narrow this city really was.

Always showing her these warm moments.

Moments she could never possess no matter what.

Yet also moments she dreamed of.

Gu Yixue reached for the cigarettes, only to find that Shen Fenghe had thrown them somewhere unknown.

How irritating.

So she kept clicking the lighter on and off.

The clicking sound echoed continuously in the quiet space.

After playing with it for a while, Gu Yixue curled up on the sofa and opened her phone to watch a movie—an old film she had seen many times.

She really liked the actress in it, who had passed away at the height of her fame and glory.

As that familiar voice played, she unknowingly fell asleep curled up on the sofa.

When Shen Fenghe came out, this was the scene she saw.

The girl was curled up on the sofa, phone resting on her lap, the movie still playing on the phone. The female lead's voice came through the speaker, saying: "If you say that, it means you don't love me~ I'm already crying and you still won't come hug me."

Not knowing what she was dreaming about, Gu Yixue's brows were slightly furrowed, and tears traced down from the corners of her eyes.

The Gu Yixue everyone usually saw was very strong. She could methodically organize an entire production crew, could nonchalantly fight with platforms.

She had the most fearless personality.

Shen Fenghe had always thought Gu Yixue was very well-behaved, just a bit quietly mischievous.

Growing up in that kind of environment from a young age, bullied by Gu Chunmian² time and time again—locked in closets, buried in sand piles, thrown into the sea—escaping death over and over.

She knew why Gu Yixue depended on her.

Because when Gu Chunmian bullied her, it was Shen Fenghe who appeared and saved her.

After it happened many times, she always felt this older sister was amazing.

But it was just a simple admiration.

This was probably just hero worship, not really love.

But Shen Fenghe wasn't expecting love either.

This kind of marriage was enough.

For her, that's how it was.

Footnotes:

¹ Jiejie (姐姐) - Literally means "older sister" in Chinese. It's commonly used as an affectionate term for an older woman, especially in romantic contexts. Here, Gu Yixue uses it flirtatiously with her wife Shen Fenghe.

² Gu Chunmian - A character who appears to be related to Gu Yixue (likely a sibling or cousin from the same family) who bullied her severely during childhood.

Chapter 177-9

Shen Fenghe believed that people should put more energy into work—romantic entanglements affected judgment too much.

But seeing Gu Yixue crying in her dreams, she always felt her heart being tugged at a little.

When she was young, aside from Shen Hui, she probably took care of this little neighbor girl the most.

But for some reason, this little sister became increasingly rebellious later on, always carrying a roguish air about her.

If she had to use one word to accurately describe Gu Yixue, Shen Fenghe felt it would be: untamed.

Only Gu Yixue had this kind of energy.

The things Gu Yixue thought Shen Fenghe didn't know about—Shen Fenghe had actually seen many times.

Shen Fenghe raised her hand to wipe the tears from the corners of Gu Yixue's eyes, then turned off her phone.

She picked up the phone from Gu Yixue's lap and set it aside, only to see a text message from the platform: 【Quella, if you don't know when to advance and retreat like this, you'll offend people! The domestic market isn't like overseas—it's not somewhere you can dominate single-handedly.】

Shen Fenghe frowned slightly after seeing it, casually swiped down and replied: 【Get lost.】

Then she turned off the phone and tossed it aside.

She stood there looking at Gu Yixue for quite a while before finally reaching out to pick her up and place her on the bed.

Shen Fenghe sighed helplessly, her voice very low: "Still the same as when you were little."

Gu Yixue sniffled and nuzzled closer to her. Shen Fenghe covered her with the blanket and patted her back, saying softly: "Stubborn."

Sure enough, Gu Yixue had a falling out with the platform over the casting issue.

The person who had come to liaise with Gu Yixue was someone with some clout at the platform. After receiving that text message from Gu Yixue, he was so angry he couldn't sleep all night.

The next day, he went to the office and complained, saying he wanted to replace Gu Yixue no matter what.

Someone like Gu Yixue was just using her bit of fame to do as she pleased.

She couldn't possibly make a good production.

Gu Yixue was fine though. After waking up from her nap, she found her phone was off. When she turned it back on, she discovered someone had used her phone to send the word "get lost."

She grinned foolishly at that "get lost" for five minutes. If it weren't for the concern that too much smiling would cause crow's feet, she would definitely have laughed longer.

It was obvious that Shen Fenghe had used her phone to send it.

Gu Yixue was in a great mood and even sent Shen Fenghe a message: 【Good morning, wife.】

Shen Fenghe: 【...】

When she arrived at the platform's office, she heard that the investor for "Sharp Edge" had been changed.

The liaison who had come to complain stared at Gu Yixue with a dumbfounded expression.

Gu Yixue looked at him disdainfully. "Which company is it now?"

Someone else answered: "Jiahe."

It was under the Shen family.

Gu Yixue's lips curved slightly: "Oh~"

"So now I get to decide the casting, right?" Gu Yixue said.

The other party: "...Yes."

The platform was completely subdued by this turn of events and had no temper left. Everyone privately discussed just what Gu Yixue's background was—how could she just change investors like that?

To compensate Guo Xinran, the platform gave her another S+ drama, but this was met with dissatisfaction from Guo Xinran.

Guo Xinran just wanted to act in "Sharp Edge."

She had also recognized the commercial value of "Sharp Edge."

It was just that the Liang family was currently in chaos.

This opportunity to collaborate with the platform on an S+ production was something she had seized amid the chaos. If Liang Xinzhou found out, there would definitely be another commotion.

But there weren't many opportunities left for Guo Xinran.

Guo Xinran could only continue making a fuss with the platform, but her fussing annoyed them so much that they directly gave her the cold shoulder.

On the day "Sharp Edge" was officially announced, Guo Xinran saw that the actress playing Qiao Wenyu was—Liang Shi.

Guo Xinran sulked in her room for an entire day. When evening came, she called Zhang Yangning, her voice cold and carrying a sense of burning-the-boats¹ determination: "Do it."

Zhang Yangning was somewhat hesitant on the other end: "Now?"

Guo Xinran nodded: "Yes."

"Didn't you say to wait until the old lady in your family died?" Zhang Yangning said. "Did she die?"

"Not yet." Guo Xinran said. "Once she dies, I'll lose my backing. She needs to stay alive. I'll help her get revenge and make her happy."

Zhang Yangning scoffed: "That doesn't sound like you."

"What? Gone soft?" Zhang Yangning asked.

Guo Xinran's tone was impatient: "Just do what I tell you to do. Why so many questions?"

"Just asking." Zhang Yangning paused for a moment, then continued: "But she's just a fake. Why do you keep targeting her? When Sun Chengcheng messed with her before, Liang Xinzhou already suspected you. Now if we actually do it..."

"The old lady is seriously ill. He won't dare do anything to me." Guo Xinran said. "If Liang Xinzhou touches me now, he'd be pushing my mother to death. That fake is nothing, but she's been in the Liang family for so many years. Everyone knows she was the most favored one. And the result? She wants to snatch everything."

Guo Xinran scoffed: "I just can't stand people taking what's mine."

Zhang Yangning: "...Fine then. I just like this attitude of yours."

"Do it." Guo Xinran reiterated.

Zhang Yangning agreed.

Liang Shi went to bed the night before with everything calm and peaceful. The next day when she woke up, she found the trending searches had exploded.

#LiangShiPersonaCollapse#

#LiangShiNightclubPhotos#

#LiangShiChaoticPrivateLife#

#TheFakePrincess'sDebauchedLife#

"..."

Several trending topics in a row, all about Liang Shi.

To be precise, about the original host.

Photos from nightclubs, as well as GIFs of the original host partying with others on luxury yachts and drinking and dancing at clubs.

The most reassuring thing was that no bedroom photos had leaked.

Footnotes:

¹ "Burning the boats" (破釜沉舟, pò fǔ chén zhōu) - A Chinese idiom meaning to cut off all means of retreat, showing absolute determination. It originates from a historical story where a general ordered his troops to sink their boats and break their cooking pots after crossing a river, forcing them to fight to the death since there was no way to retreat.

Chapter 177-10

Liang Shi's scalp went numb when she saw those photos. She didn't really want to click on them.

She didn't want to admit those were her at all.

These were all things Liang Xinzhou had dealt with before. Liang Shi never expected there would be a day when they'd be exposed.

But what happened had happened—it was hard to say it didn't exist.

What followed was a grand feeding frenzy of exposure.

Soon, Xu Qingzhu's identity was also dug up.

Netizens discovered Liang Shi's alternate account by going through Xu Qingzhu's previous livestreams.

Liang Shi's alternate account didn't really have anything on it—she just occasionally liked some movie promotional Weibo posts and such.

But it did confirm that Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were married.

This made everyone's impression of Xu Qingzhu turn negative as well, so the first thing Xu Qingzhu did when she woke up was deal with the falling stock prices.

Liang Shi had a splitting headache.

But what was meant to come would always come.

Crisis PR also had its methods—make good use of the golden 24 hours and reverse the public opinion trend as quickly as possible.

The more disadvantaged you were, the calmer you needed to be.

What Liang Shi feared most right now was those people releasing the original host's bedroom photos—that really would be impossible to clear up.

Even solo bedroom photos would be somewhat acceptable, since the original host was single at the time. But she hoped there weren't photos from when the original host was into BDSM¹ and had certain addictions.

Otherwise... not even divine intervention could save her.

Especially since "Sharp Edge" had just been officially announced yesterday.

It was hard to say Guo Xinran wasn't involved in this.

But now wasn't the time to pursue the mastermind behind the scenes. The most important thing was to get through this crisis.

Liang Shi first confirmed the authenticity of these photos, then went to the company to meet with her agent to discuss how to handle this.

This trending search was different from all the previous ones. It was like it was premeditated, exposing all her disgraceful incidents. Countless marketing accounts came out in droves, all attacking one point: chaotic private life.

And suspected cheating.

If this were really the case, given everyone's fondness for Xu Qingzhu, they definitely wouldn't be able to tolerate her.

And Xu Qingzhu was already close to her due date...

Liang Shi was truly on high alert about this matter.

While she was at the company discussing with her agent how to handle things—

On the other side of the city, the Shen family was having breakfast together, all neat and tidy.

It had been a long time since they'd eaten breakfast together.

Shen Siyan and Shen Hui had the weekend off. Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe had come home last night and hadn't gone to work yet this morning.

Shen Yaobo had just finished reading the financial newspaper and handed his reading glasses to the housekeeper. Zhu Mingqi then brought up the matter of everyone going on a trip together—they'd talked about it many times but never followed through. It had been three years since their last family outing.

Zhu Mingqi was coordinating everyone's schedules.

Shen Hui said she still hadn't taken her annual leave this year. Shen Siyan said she was available anytime, preferably during winter or summer break. Gu Yixue also had a flexible schedule. Everyone's eyes fell on Shen Fenghe.

Under the pressure, Shen Fenghe could only brace herself and say: "Around the middle of each month, the company is relatively less busy."

Only then did Zhu Mingqi beam with joy, patting her on the head: "That's Mama's good girl."

Shen Fenghe: "..."

She glanced at Gu Yixue and said awkwardly to Zhu Mingqi: "Mom, how old am I already?"

Zhu Mingqi said matter-of-factly: "No matter how old you are, you're still my daughter."

Shen Fenghe was helpless. She lowered her head to eat, but caught Gu Yixue secretly laughing out of the corner of her eye. She frowned and said coldly: "What are you laughing at?"

Zhu Mingqi heard this and lightly tapped her forehead with her chopsticks: "If you want to talk, just talk. Why are you being fierce with Xiaoxue? Eldest, let me tell you, this is how you make your wife angry."

"It's fine." Gu Yixue immediately came to Shen Fenghe's rescue. "Fenghe-jie just has this kind of personality."

"You just spoil her." Zhu Mingqi looked at Gu Yixue—the more she looked, the more beautiful she found her. "You two have been married for so long, and you're still calling her Fenghe-jie? Just call her by her name."

"Mom!" Shen Fenghe protested.

But Zhu Mingqi called out: "Husband!"

Shen Yaobo immediately looked toward Shen Fenghe, and Shen Fenghe gave up².

Shen Hui shook her head. "Tsk. Mom, can you change this habit of tattling?"

Zhu Mingqi scoffed: "If you have the ability, you tattle too."

Shen Hui: "...Childish."

Shen Siyan silently placed a fried egg on Shen Hui's plate.

Amid this "harmonious" atmosphere, Zhu Mingqi received a call from an unknown number.

Shen Hui and Gu Yixue were the type who liked browsing Weibo. They soon also saw the trending topics exploding one after another.

Gu Yixue sent a message to Liang Shi: 【Need help?】

Shen Hui took a screenshot and sent it to Zhao Xuning: 【Tsk, your good friend crashed and burned.】

Zhao Xuning replied instantly: 【You're really not going to help?】

Shen Hui: 【Why should I help?】

Zhao Xuning changed the subject: 【Have you eaten?】

Shen Hui: 【Eating right now.】

Zhao Xuning: 【I haven't eaten yet.】

Shen Hui: 【What does that have to do with me?】

Zhao Xuning: 【Wife... I'm hungry.】

Shen Hui: 【...】

Damn it.

After all these years, she still couldn't handle Zhao Xuning acting weak.

Shen Hui smiled as she tapped on the screen: 【Got it. I'll come eat with you in a bit.】

Zhao Xuning: 【I'm at your front door.】

Shen Hui: 【?】

She glanced out the window. Sure enough, there was a silver-white car parked outside the villa. She was just about to message Zhao Xuning saying she'd be right out when she heard Zhu Mingqi slam down her chopsticks and stand up, her voice sharp: "What do you mean?"

Footnotes:

¹ "Playing with letters" (玩字母) - Chinese internet slang that refers to BDSM activities. The "letters" refer to the English abbreviation BDSM (Bondage, Discipline, Sadism, Masochism). Combined with the mention of "addiction" (X癮, where X likely refers to 性/sex), this indicates the original host had been involved in such activities.

² "Gave up" (偃旗息鼓, yǎn qí xī gǔ) - Literally means "to lower the flags and silence the drums," a military idiom meaning to cease all activities or give up resistance. Here it means Shen Fenghe stopped protesting when her father looked at her.

Chapter 177-11

The house immediately fell silent.

Only an aged voice could be heard from the phone receiver: "Your daughter is still alive. Give me one million, and I'll tell you where your daughter is."

"Is that Auntie Wang?" Shen Hui had sharp ears and recognized the voice. She mouthed the question to Shen Fenghe.

Shen Fenghe nodded.

Zhu Mingqi asked: "How can you prove it?"

"Madam, I need money right now. I wouldn't lie to you." Auntie Wang said. "My son is lying in the ICU right now. I need this money. Your daughter really didn't die. The one you buried back then was Sister Guihua's brother's daughter. You were all crying so hard at the time that no one looked closely... Plus the child was already in that state, so Sister Guihua switched them. She had me take the baby and throw her by the garbage bins outside the hospital. That child still had a breath of life in her at the time."

Shen Hui sent a message to Zhao Xuning: 【Something happened at my house.】

Zhao Xuning: 【What?】

Shen Hui: 【A former servant from my family called to extort us.】

Just as her words fell, the doorbell at home rang.

Shen Siyan saw it was Zhao Xuning and sat there without moving.

Shen Hui raised her hand to have the servant open the door.

After Zhao Xuning came in, she didn't dare speak. Shen Hui immediately stood up and pulled her to her side.

They heard the voice on the phone continue: "Madam, really, how would I dare to lie to you? My son is waiting for this money to save his life. I really do know who took your daughter away. Back then, she definitely made a deal with Sister Guihua. I was just momentarily confused and listened to Sister Guihua's words... Anyway, that child was about to die, but unexpectedly she was blessed with good fortune and is actually still alive."

"Then why don't you go extort her?" Zhu Mingqi questioned coldly.

Auntie Wang was stunned, then said in a choked voice: "Madam, I haven't been able to reach her phone for a long time. She told me that child had died and had already been thrown into the sea. But I saw the news these past few days and realized everything she said was lies. Madam, I'm not lying to you. Please save my child's life."

Zhao Xuning had come in partway through, but she'd heard most of it. She asked Shen Hui in a low voice.

Shen Hui leaned close to her ear and explained the whole story.

Zhao Xuning's expression changed slightly.

In the end, Zhu Mingqi agreed and had someone wire her one million.

Auntie Wang wasn't stupid either. She said she would tell her daughter's whereabouts once the one million was transferred to her account.

After Zhu Mingqi hung up the phone, she braced herself weakly against the table, nearly collapsing.

Shen Yaobo supported her, giving her something to lean on.

Zhu Mingqi was about to tell the butler to wire the money to Auntie Wang when Zhao Xuning called out: "Wait."

The whole family looked at her in unison.

Zhao Xuning was the type who only hesitated at the moment of making a choice, but was very decisive once she'd made her decision. So she said cleanly and clearly: "I know where she is."

Everyone was shocked.

Shen Hui grabbed her wrist. "What nonsense are you talking?"

"I'm not talking nonsense." Zhao Xuning held her hand in return, but her gaze was directed at Zhu Mingqi. "Would you want to acknowledge her?"

Zhu Mingqi pressed her lips together: "She's really still alive?"

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Alive, and very healthy."

Gu Yixue seemed to have already understood something. She scrolled through today's trending searches, found the costume photos from Liang Shi's "Journey of the Heart" from before, looked at the photo, then glanced at Shen Fenghe.

Then she silently placed her phone in front of Shen Fenghe.

Shen Fenghe was still listening to Zhao Xuning speak. Seeing Gu Yixue do this, she lowered her head to look.

In an instant, enlightenment struck.

"She went and got a DNA test done, so it's real." Zhao Xuning came clean with them directly. "But I don't know what her concerns were—she kept this matter hidden. It's been over a month now. Today, she ran into some trouble, and she's still at the top of the trending searches."

Shen Hui was stunned: "Huh?"

Everyone was shocked, but Shen Hui was the only one who made a sound.

Zhao Xuning looked down at her, saw her dazed expression, pinched her face, then quickly let go.

Shen Hui opened the trending searches and found Liang Shi's name there.

She clicked in and out, her shock evident on her face.

Shen Yaobo and Zhu Mingqi both opened their phones.

Shen Siyan stared at the screen, still in disbelief: "You're lying to us, right?"

Zhao Xuning showed them the DNA test report images that Liang Shi had sent her before, using the data to prove its authenticity.

Shen Hui raised a question: "How did she get the samples?"

Zhao Xuning told them truthfully about what happened that day.

But she also glossed over some unspeakable details.

The reason she was able to get Shen Hui's hair that day was because Shen Hui had come to see her. As they talked, Shen Hui had gotten so angry she cried.

She didn't know how to comfort her, so she went forward and hugged her, then leaned down to kiss Shen Hui. Her fingers slid into her long hair, and when the kiss ended, she casually plucked out a strand of hair.

As for how Liang Shi got that white hair of hers, she had no idea.

But Zhu Mingqi remembered what happened that day.

She felt somewhat dazed. "No wonder I always felt she was so familiar... I kept wanting her to be my daughter-in-law."

Gu Yixue & Zhao Xuning: "?"

Zhu Mingqi's eyes had already reddened. Before she could fully process everything, Auntie Wang's call came through again.

"Madam, why haven't you wired the money yet? Don't you want to know where your daughter is?" Auntie Wang's tone was anxious.

Zhu Mingqi let out a light breath. "I'll only give you two hundred thousand. Tell me clearly who Yang Gui¹ was colluding with, how you committed the crime, and how you switched the babies—explain everything to me one by one."

"Two hundred thousand won't work, Madam. It won't save my son's life." Auntie Wang was still bargaining.

"I'll count to ten." Zhu Mingqi's tone was cold and harsh. "If you haven't told me by then, I won't give you a single cent. I already know who my daughter is now, and I'll go find her. But your son is in the ICU—he can't wait."

Footnotes:

¹ Yang Gui (楊桂) - Also referred to as "Sister Guihua" (桂花姐) in the conversation. "Guihua" is her given name, and Yang is her surname. She appears to be the mastermind servant who orchestrated the baby switch.

Chapter 177-12

Auntie Wang panicked.

Zhu Mingqi had already started counting down.

When she counted to five, Auntie Wang immediately said in a panic: "Sister Guihua took money from Miss Qiu. Her gambler husband had lost three million, and if they didn't pay up, he would be turned into a human swine¹. Third Miss was weak at the time and had contracted a strange illness. Sister Guihua contacted Miss Qiu and switched Third Miss out."

"How much money did you take?" Zhu Mingqi asked.

"A hundred thousand." Auntie Wang said. "I only carried Third Miss out. I didn't do anything else."

Zhu Mingqi now understood the whole story. She hung up the phone directly and instructed the butler to wire two hundred thousand to Auntie Wang.

As for the other person involved in this matter—Yang Gui, the Sister Guihua that Auntie Wang mentioned—she had resigned in disgrace after Third Miss "passed away." Supposedly she was later beaten to death by her husband, and it had even been featured on a legal affairs program.

When Zhu Mingqi found out at the time, she had even sent someone to her hometown to pay respects.

Thinking about it now, she wished she could go stomp on her grave.

What a piece of trash!

No one could focus on eating this breakfast.

When Zhu Mingqi came back to her senses, she first asked Shen Fenghe: "Is the situation on the trending searches serious?"

Shen Fenghe said calmly: "It's already been dealt with."

The Shen family was quite experienced in handling these things. In less than five minutes, all the related trending topics had been removed, and the search terms couldn't be found anymore.

"That's good." Zhu Mingqi sat there and let out a soft breath. Shen Yaobo poured her a glass of water and handed it over. "Don't panic. If she's our daughter, we'll acknowledge her. Don't be afraid."

"I really never expected this." Zhu Mingqi laughed coldly. "She could actually do something like this. What a beast."

Shen Yaobo paused: "It's Qiu Zimin, right?"

Zhu Mingqi: "Who else could it be?"

Shen Yaobo said through gritted teeth: "A romantic debt left behind by Shen Chi."

Zhu Mingqi: "..."

"If you had managed her properly, would she have become like this?" Zhu Mingqi glared at him.

Shen Yaobo's tone immediately turned sour: "After all these years, you're still taking her side."

Zhu Mingqi: "..."

The two bickered for a bit, but finally managed to calm down.

But the question that followed was: Why didn't Liang Shi want to acknowledge them?

Zhu Mingqi murmured quietly to Shen Yaobo: "Did I not behave well enough? Does she not like me?"

Shen Yaobo comforted her: "It's definitely not that. She probably has her own concerns."

Even the usually inarticulate Shen Fenghe joined the comforting camp: "There must be some unspeakable difficulties."

Gu Yixue added: "She's living quite well now, with a wife and children. She probably chose not to acknowledge you because she doesn't want any changes to her life."

Hearing this, Zhu Mingqi felt even worse.

She kept thinking: How much suffering did my child endure where I couldn't see?

The whole morning was thrown into chaos.

Meanwhile, Zhao Xuning sent Liang Shi a message: 【Come over.】

She sent her location directly.

Liang Shi was confused and asked her: 【Did you handle the trending searches for me?】

Zhao Xuning: 【Sort of.】

Liang Shi: 【You're really such a good person!】

Zhao Xuning: 【...】

Zhao Xuning still planned to meddle a bit more today and give Liang Shi a push.

So after hesitating, she still didn't tell her the truth.

However, she also messaged Xu Qingzhu, asking her to come over as well, so Liang Shi would have some support.

After Zhao Xuning finished messaging Liang Shi, she was still doing some self-reflection. She used to be someone who never meddled in other people's affairs. What was happening to her now? She was even meddling in something like this?

Spending too much time with Liang Shi really did make the habit of meddling contagious.

Liang Shi was also surprised that the trending searches related to her had vanished in an instant.

Even her agent felt like she was dreaming and finally asked if President Xu had stepped in.

This kind of operation clearly looked like capital intervening.

But Liang Shi shook her head: "It's probably not her."

This style looked more like Liang Xinzhou.

But when she called Liang Xinzhou, his line showed as busy. She then called Yu Wan, who said Liang Xinzhou hadn't been home for two days and had been running back and forth between the hospital and the company, so busy he was dizzy.

Liang Shi knew then that it probably wasn't Liang Xinzhou—he couldn't spare the attention.

Afterward, she also called Liang Xinhe. Liang Xinhe was also confused and asked her how all that negative material had gotten exposed.

Liang Shi was angry and snapped at him in the process: "Isn't it because of your dear sister!"

Liang Xinhe: "?"

Liang Shi had already hung up.

Afterward, Liang Xinhe messaged her: 【Was it really Guo Xinran who did this?】

Liang Shi: 【Once I find the evidence, I'll definitely throw it in your face!】

Liang Xinhe: 【...I'll go investigate for you.】

Liang Shi didn't reply to him again, then received Zhao Xuning's message.

Following her location, she drove over. It was a very luxurious villa district. Liang Shi thought it was a new property Zhao Xuning had acquired and didn't think much of it.

Just as she was pressing the doorbell, she heard Xu Qingzhu calling her. She turned around and found Xu Qingzhu behind her.

Liang Shi asked her: "Why are you here?"

"Dr. Zhao asked me to come." Xu Qingzhu said.

Actually, Zhao Xuning had told Xu Qingzhu everything, but asked her to keep it from Liang Shi for now.

But they had already arrived at the door, the doorbell had been pressed, and the servant had opened the door.

So Xu Qingzhu didn't hide it anymore. She told Liang Shi in a low voice: "They already know everything."

Liang Shi hadn't processed it yet, but the moment she walked in and saw a roomful of people standing in a row, she suddenly understood.

It was just... very surreal.

Shen Yaobo, Zhu Mingqi, Shen Fenghe, Shen Hui, and Shen Siyan were standing in a row looking at her. Gu Yixue and Zhao Xuning stood off to the side, looking somewhat awkward.

Footnotes:

¹ Human swine (人彘, rén zhì) - An extremely cruel form of punishment from ancient China where a person's limbs are cut off, eyes gouged out, ears burned, and other mutilations performed, leaving them as a "human pig." Here it's used as a threat for what loan sharks would do if the gambling debt wasn't paid.

Chapter 177-13

Seeing this scene, Liang Shi didn't know what to say for a moment.

She had originally thought she would feel some kind of apprehension about returning home¹, but at this moment she felt fine.

Probably because she had spent over a month building herself up mentally, so she didn't have much of a reaction.

Until Zhu Mingqi opened her mouth and called out to her: "A-Shi."

"Auntie Zhu." Liang Shi still greeted her the same way.

This single sentence made Zhu Mingqi's eyes turn red. Shen Yaobo supported her while also staring fixedly at Liang Shi.

Shen Siyan asked in disbelief: "You're really my third sister?"

Liang Shi: "...The DNA test report says so."

Shen Siyan pinched her ear and said awkwardly: "Alright then."

Then she was the first to call out: "Third Sister."

Liang Shi: "?"

Shen Fenghe and Shen Hui were also staring at her, their expressions seeming to say—aren't you going to greet us?

But Liang Shi didn't call out to them. She took half a step back and stood beside Xu Qingzhu. "I'm not mentally prepared yet."

"When will you be mentally prepared?" Zhu Mingqi immediately said. "I can wait."

Liang Shi: "..."

These words were too heartbreaking. Liang Shi immediately felt embarrassed.

But most importantly, Liang Shi looked at them: "How did you all find out?"

Then her gaze turned to Zhao Xuning. Zhao Xuning shrugged: "Although I was the one who said it in the end, even if I didn't say it, someone else would have, so I just said it. You understand?"

This long tongue-twister was hard to follow.

But Liang Shi understood.

She sat on the sofa, facing this large group of people in silence.

She could only relieve her awkwardness and nervousness by constantly squeezing Xu Qingzhu's fingers.

Zhu Mingqi had been carefully not moving, but her eyes kept glancing toward Liang Shi. Every five minutes she would ask Liang Shi: "Are you mentally prepared yet?"

The tearful dramatic scene she had expected didn't arrive. This family was quite rational.

Everyone was waiting for Liang Shi to make a decision.

Even the workaholic Shen Fenghe didn't go to the company.

After about half an hour of awkward silence, Liang Shi spoke up first: "Why do you want to acknowledge me?"

Zhu Mingqi felt her question made no sense and answered her matter-of-factly: "You're my daughter. When I didn't know, that was one thing. Now that I know, why wouldn't I acknowledge you? I carried you for ten months and gave birth to you."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "But I've already grown up now. If I come back, I might disrupt your existing balance, so... wouldn't it be better to pretend not to know?"

This was what Liang Shi had been worried about all along.

But the moment these words came out, Zhu Mingqi's eyes welled up with tears. Even Shen Hui secretly got red-eyed.

Zhu Mingqi walked over and half-knelt in front of Liang Shi. She raised her hand to touch her face and said in a choked voice: "You are my daughter. What balance is there to talk about? You should be part of this family. I'm so sorry you've grown up, but I've already missed more than twenty years of watching you grow. How can I miss any more of your growth?"

By the end, she was already sobbing uncontrollably.

Zhu Mingqi's tears fell like rain as she choked out: "What parent would ever despise their own child? I carried you for ten months and gave birth to you—I never thought about any balance. Just how much have you suffered that you always think of others first?"

Liang Shi was suddenly struck in the softest place of her heart.

Even Xu Qingzhu felt her heart ache when she heard that last sentence.

Pregnant women were already emotionally sensitive to begin with, and a tear dropped directly.

Liang Shi's eyes also reddened.

When no one was there to comfort you, you felt like you could weather any storm alone.

But once someone showed concern, once someone asked if you'd been doing well all these years, you would suddenly feel wronged.

The truth was, things hadn't been good.

Fighting alone in an unfamiliar place.

When others were warmly reuniting amid the lights of countless homes, she was watching TV in a cold, lonely house.

No one around her, emptiness in her heart.

Zhu Mingqi was choking up so much she could barely speak: "Come home from now on. Your family won't let you suffer anymore. Wherever Mom and Dad are, that's your home."

Liang Shi's tears fell. She had thought she could hold it in well, but she ended up crying out loud anyway.

It wasn't earth-shattering crying, just soft sobbing.

Yet it revealed all the hardships and grievances she had endured over the years.

She had originally thought acknowledging her relatives was a big deal that would overturn her existing life.

But just like when Xu Qingzhu acknowledged Su Yao before, it seemed big, but it was actually just a big emotional change.

All day long she had been tangled up in her own thoughts, exhausting herself internally.

When she actually acknowledged them, she discovered it was just a small matter in life.

Life would go on as it should.

Except... there were now more bonds.

After Liang Shi's matters trended, there were also follow-ups.

The author Wenchuan posted a Weibo: If Qiao Wenyu has a prototype, it's @LiangShi. The story of two little girls saving each other in childhood—no one can understand it better than her. Jiao-jie is Xu Jiao, but also the Jiao in my life that I don't want to mention, and also the Jiao who once warmed her childhood.

I'm also grateful that she pulled me out of the mire.

As for her character, people can judge for themselves.

When Liang Shi finished being busy and went online, she also saw this Weibo post. She felt like it was all very confusing.

Until Gu Xingyue sent her a WeChat message: 【Have you finished reading the script? I'm planning to write the second part, "Blade."】

Liang Shi: 【???】

It was only then that she learned Gu Xingyue was Wenchuan.

And the two characters "Wenchuan" (文川) were derived from "Qi" (齊)².

The extra stroke at the bottom also represented her refusal to give in to this world.

Beyond her shock, Liang Shi also understood where all those feelings she'd had before came from.

Because those were all things she had experienced.

Qiao Wenyu in the book was her. Xu Jiao was her.

And the one who endured so much suffering and finally saw the light of day was still her.

Thankfully, there was still Qi Jiao, still Gu Xingyue.

They all found their way to the light in different places.

Footnotes:

¹ "Apprehension about returning home" (近鄉情怯, jìn xiāng qíng qiè) - A Chinese idiom describing the mixed feelings of nervousness and anxiety one feels when approaching home after a long absence, particularly when uncertain about what reception awaits.

² The pen name "Wenchuan" (文川) is a clever wordplay. The Chinese character "齊" (Qí, as in Qi Jiao's surname) can be split into components that loosely resemble "文" (wén, literature/writing) and "川" (chuān, river/streams). By adding an extra stroke, it transforms into something new while retaining a connection to the original character—symbolizing Gu Xingyue's determination to forge a new identity while honoring Qi Jiao's memory.

Chapter 177-14

Liang Xinhe went to investigate the trending search matter. He only traced it back to Zhang Yangning, but the name sounded familiar, so he went to discuss it with Liang Xinzhou.

Liang Xinzhou, who had been so busy his feet barely touched the ground, finally had time to look at the trending searches and learned about those matters.

He had sent people to deal with those old photos and videos before.

But clearly, the person who leaked this information had been prepared in advance and even had a complete strategy for stirring up public opinion.

Liang Xinzhou could tell at a glance who had done it.

After Qiu Zimin fell sound asleep, Liang Xinzhou went directly to find Guo Xinran.

At that moment, Guo Xinran had just recovered from a hangover and was lying on the sofa with a headache. When she heard the urgent doorbell, she wanted to smash the door. When she got up to answer it, she was quite irritated.

But the moment she opened the door and saw Liang Xinzhou's cold face, she sobered up on the spot.

"Big Brother, Second Brother." Guo Xinran smiled awkwardly. "Why are you here?"

"To see what you've done." Liang Xinzhou sneered. "Guo Xinran, I warned you—once you entered the entertainment industry, you should just do your own thing, understand? Don't covet any position you can't reach. You're not worthy."

These words were too harsh.

Guo Xinran's face immediately flushed red. "Big... Big Brother, what do you mean?"

Liang Xinzhou looked at her: "You're colluding with Zhang Yangning, aren't you? I thought her losing her job was the final warning for her and you, but you couldn't stay quiet for even half a year before starting again. Yes, the Liang family owes you, but since you came back, no one has mistreated you in the slightest. We gave you a house to live in, cards to spend, and when you wanted to enter the entertainment industry, I paved the way for you. What exactly do you want? Do you want the Liang family, or do you want the Liang family destroyed?!"

Every word was incisive, killing without drawing blood.

Liang Xinzhou had no more patience to deal with her.

Qiu Zimin's health was getting worse by the day. Liang Xinzhou was alone and couldn't handle so many things.

He hadn't seen his son and wife for three days now.

Liang Xinzhou was also about to be crushed by this pressure.

He directly gave Guo Xinran an ultimatum: "I'll give you two choices. One: Take enough money to last you a lifetime and go abroad, or go somewhere none of us can see you. In short, leave Haizhou. Two: Stay in the entertainment industry, but as long as Dongheng is in my hands, I won't help you for a single day. You're completely on your own."

After Liang Xinzhou finished speaking and was about to leave, Guo Xinran grabbed onto the door and suddenly asked loudly: "Why? I'm your real sister, aren't I?"

Liang Xinzhou closed his eyes briefly and sighed with utter exhaustion: "You're too greedy."

Wanting everything.

But her abilities didn't yet match her ambitions.

Liang Xinzhou said: "Your ambitions are written plainly in your eyes, but you don't have the capability yet. When I was fighting my way through the business world, who knows where you were playing around."

Guo Xinran was unconvinced, but then she heard Liang Xinzhou say: "I'll make the decision for you—option one. I'll have someone release your retirement announcement from the industry."

Liang Xinzhou acted quickly, directly having someone release Guo Xinran's retirement announcement. When he returned to the hospital, he found a crowd of people gathered at the door of Qiu Zimin's ward—some he recognized, some he didn't.

Liang Xinzhou immediately went forward and found that the ward was already in complete chaos.

Qiu Zimin was sitting on the hospital bed, extremely weak, but glaring at the person across from her like a venomous snake: "Zhu Mingqi! What exactly makes you better than me? Why does everyone like you?! Yaobo-ge¹, don't you know she's treating you as a substitute?!"

"What nonsense are you spouting?" Zhu Mingqi was furious. "Back then, Shen Chi and I were completely innocent. Shen Chi liking me was her own business—if you have the guts, go yell at Shen Chi. What happened between Shen Yaobo and me was two years after Shen Chi died. How is that being a substitute? Have you been reading too many novels?! Qiu Zimin, I used to genuinely treat you as a friend, as a bestie. Look at what despicable things you've done! Your own daughter went missing, so you bribed my family's servants to steal my daughter. I really..."

Zhu Mingqi was so angry that even the finger pointing at Qiu Zimin was trembling. Her whole body was shaking.

She let out a light breath, but in her fury, she could only manage to say: "You're this sick now! It's your own doing! Serves you right! Scheming all day long, calculating against this person and that person! If you don't get sick, who will?!"

"Enough!" Liang Xinzhou shouted to stop them. He strode to Qiu Zimin's bedside, his tall figure standing between Qiu Zimin and Zhu Mingqi. "Auntie, my mother is not well. If you have anything to say, please say it to me."

"So you're Qiu Zimin's son?" Zhu Mingqi glanced at him. "What do I have to say to you? Move aside."

When Zhu Mingqi argued with Qiu Zimin, it was just like elementary school students.

Zhu Mingqi didn't curse, but she could still provoke Qiu Zimin.

Later, she learned that Qiu Zimin had breast cancer, and it was late-stage—related to her years of pent-up emotions and resentment.

Zhu Mingqi suddenly didn't know how to scold her anymore and could only vent like this.

Though as soon as she entered the ward, she had slapped Qiu Zimin without a word, and only afterward came the elementary school-style argument.

In the past, she could never out-argue Qiu Zimin, but now Qiu Zimin couldn't out-argue her.

Zhu Mingqi couldn't feel happy about it either. After walking out of the hospital, she sat on a bench with Shen Yaobo sitting beside her.

Footnotes:

¹ Yaobo-ge (耀博哥) - "Ge" means "older brother" and is used here as a familiar/affectionate way to address Shen Yaobo. Qiu Zimin using this term suggests she had a close relationship with him in the past, likely through their social circle when they were younger.

Chapter 177-15

After a long while, Zhu Mingqi suddenly burst into sorrowful tears: "How did we... end up like this?"

Actually, the beginning of the story was quite simple.

Shen Chi, as an emotional painter, was beautiful and also a smooth-talking Alpha, so naturally many people liked her.

Qiu Zimin and Zhu Mingqi were close friends first. Later, through Zhu Mingqi, Qiu Zimin got to know Shen Chi.

The Zhu family and the Shen family were old family friends, so Shen Chi and Zhu Mingqi's relationship was closer.

Zhu Mingqi was using Shen Chi to get close to Shen Yaobo.

But Shen Chi liked Zhu Mingqi.

And Qiu Zimin liked Shen Chi, to the point of infatuation.

The two had even dated briefly, but Shen Chi said they weren't compatible.

She thought Qiu Zimin had let go, but in reality, Qiu Zimin was only watching her flirt with Zhu Mingqi, growing more and more jealous.

The friendship among the three gradually fractured and died amid these emotions, though on the surface everything still appeared smooth.

Neither Zhu Mingqi nor Shen Chi knew what Qiu Zimin was thinking.

Until Shen Chi was diagnosed with a serious illness and disappeared abroad without telling anyone.

Only then did Qiu Zimin explode at Zhu Mingqi, demanding to know why.

Then their relationship broke down, and they were no longer sisters.

Zhu Mingqi later fell in love with Shen Yaobo and married him.

Qiu Zimin also married Liang Zu under her family's persuasion, and life was fairly smooth at first.

But then she heard that Zhu Mingqi had given birth to a third daughter, while her own daughter had been stolen.

After giving birth to two sons in a row, Qiu Zimin desperately wanted a daughter. She felt a daughter might have Shen Chi's shadow in her.

But unexpectedly, her daughter was stolen.

She happened to see Yang Gui's embarrassing situation of borrowing money everywhere, and so this idea came to her.

At first, she wanted to strangle Zhu Mingqi's daughter—after all, it looked like she wouldn't live much longer anyway.

But she thought it would be even better to raise Zhu Mingqi's daughter into a failure, and then she could take revenge on Zhu Mingqi.

And so, a plan that would lie dormant for over twenty years was born.

However, things didn't go as she wished—Liang Shi still didn't turn out badly.

After Zhu Mingqi and the others left the ward, Qiu Zimin sat there motionlessly.

After a while, she suddenly spat a mouthful of blood directly onto the hospital bed—her fury had attacked her heart¹.

That same day, she fell into a coma.

In less than three days, she passed away.

Before she died, she said to Liang Xinzhou: "Take care of your younger brother and sister."

She thought, she was going to find Shen Chi now.

Qiu Zimin's death caught everyone off guard.

Zhu Mingqi even fell into self-blame over it, wondering if she had gone too far by going to the hospital to settle accounts with her that day.

But thinking about it later, anyone who learned about those things wouldn't have been able to hold back.

She had done the right thing.

But with Qiu Zimin dying like this, it made it seem like she had done something wrong.

Shen Yaobo comforted her for a while, and the Shen family members also took turns trying to console her. But Zhu Mingqi still remained bedridden, showing signs of falling ill.

Everyone had no choice but to go find Liang Shi.

After Liang Shi entered her room, she thought for a moment and asked: "Would you like to go shopping with me?"

Zhu Mingqi: "?!"

Zhu Mingqi was instantly revived to full health.

When they went shopping, they were buying baby supplies. Every time they passed by such stores, Zhu Mingqi would mention things from when Liang Shi was little.

They had clearly only known each other for about a month, but Zhu Mingqi had so many things to talk about.

How happy Zhu Mingqi had been when she was pregnant with Liang Shi—and how depressed she became after Liang Shi "passed away."

Zhu Mingqi said she had originally wanted to name her Shen Xuanyan.

Bright and beautiful like the sun.

Later, she named her fourth child Shen Siyan—"Si" meaning "to miss," missing Shen Xuanyan.

Shen Siyan's name contained her within it.

Every time this was mentioned to Shen Siyan, she would eat an extra half bowl of rice, saying she was living well on behalf of her sister.

Even though Liang Shi had already heard about this, hearing it again from Zhu Mingqi still moved her.

However...

"The name I didn't get to use—let's give it to my children." Liang Shi said. "One character each, just enough to share."

Zhu Mingqi asked about Xu Qingzhu's due date and decided to clear her schedule to take good care of Xu Qingzhu.

Without Liang Shi knowing, Zhu Mingqi had already become good friends with Su Yao and Sheng Linlang.

When Liang Shi had seen Sheng Linlang before, she had looked somewhat pale and melancholic, but recently she was obviously much better.

Liang Wanwan, who had returned from abroad to attend Qiu Zimin's funeral, also met with Liang Shi.

Liang Shi expressed her regret over Qiu Zimin's passing.

But Liang Wanwan said: "Her illness was discovered a long time ago, but she wouldn't let anyone say anything and just kept pushing through. Jie, she treated you badly all these years, but she's dead now. Consider it her atonement. Don't hate her anymore, and don't let yourself be angry."

Liang Shi naturally couldn't say anything more and just comforted her with a few words.

Qiu Zimin's funeral was kept simple.

Liang Shi also went to offer a flower and bowed.

It could be considered the dust finally settling.

Footnotes:

¹ "Fury attacked her heart" (急火攻心, jí huǒ gōng xīn) - A traditional Chinese medicine concept where extreme emotional distress, particularly anger or anxiety, causes internal damage to the body. It's believed that such intense emotions can disrupt the body's qi (vital energy) and affect the heart, potentially causing physical symptoms like vomiting blood or collapse.

Chapter 177-16

Xu Qingzhu's due date was in August, right in the hot season.

The two little ones showed no signs of movement even ten days past the due date. Zhu Mingqi was extremely anxious, constantly asking Liang Shi if they should do another checkup.

Finally, in a quiet late night, Xu Qingzhu pressed the emergency bell by the bed.

Xu Qingzhu was sent to the operating room, and Liang Shi followed her in.

Giving birth was a long process—from two in the morning until seven in the morning. This was already considered relatively smooth.

The preparatory work in the early stages had been thorough, and they didn't encounter any special situations.

But it had already caused Xu Qingzhu tremendous pain. Her tears were almost cried dry.

Liang Shi held her hand, constantly soothing her by her ear: "Baby, hang in there a little longer."

"Darling, it'll be over soon."

"Wife, be good."

"Baby, don't fall asleep."

"..."

Liang Shi was so heartbroken she wanted to cry too. Her mind kept circling around—why have children? Why have children?

But thankfully, mother and daughters were safe.

She gave birth to twin daughters.

Liang Shi had already chosen names for them early on.

She and Xu Qingzhu had been using their surnames for so many years; she was too lazy to change them.

After all, names were just labels.

But the two girls' names still used their original surnames.

One had the surname Sheng, one had the surname Shen.

The older sister was called Sheng Yan, the younger sister was called Shen Xuan¹.

To avoid overlapping with Shen Siyan's name, they had put considerable thought into it.

The two children's nicknames were given by Xu Qingzhu.

Zhaohzao and Mumu².

"If love between two hearts is long, why must they be together morning and night?"³

But being together morning and night is what makes the heart flutter.

The day Liang Shi proposed to Xu Qingzhu was a sunny, pleasant day.

That year, Zhaohzao and Mumu were four years old, already at the age for kindergarten.

Of course, they could also be flower girls.

While Xu Qingzhu was washing up, Liang Shi walked into the bathroom and hugged her from behind. The water was still running, and Xu Qingzhu had just squeezed hand soap onto her hands when Liang Shi reached over, saying sweetly: "Wife, let me help you wash."

So Xu Qingzhu stopped moving, enjoying Liang Shi's service.

But when her hands were full of foam, her finger suddenly felt something cold being slipped onto it. Only after the water rinsed away the bubbles did Xu Qingzhu see the ring on her hand.

Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi took half a step back, knelt on one knee, and looked up at her devoutly: "Xu Qingzhu, will you be with me for the rest of our lives? I will love you well."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes darted around. Although she was moved, she said stubbornly: "Where are my flowers? What kind of proposal doesn't have flowers?"

Liang Shi immediately clapped her hands.

Zhaozao and Mumu appeared wearing pink princess dresses, each holding a bouquet of flowers—passionate roses.

For a proposal, roses were needed to show sincerity.

Liang Shi smiled at Xu Qingzhu: "So, Xu Qingzhu, marry me."

Not "marry me" as in becoming hers, but "marry me" as in getting married together.

Together, they would spend the rest of their lives.

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment.

During the few seconds she was thinking, Liang Shi's heart was pounding like a drum, unable to stop.

Liang Shi said aggrievedly: "How much longer do you need to think?"

As she spoke, she even shook Xu Qingzhu's hand, meaning for her to look at the ring.

"You're already wearing the ring." Liang Shi said. "I've already claimed you in my embrace."

Xu Qingzhu cleared her throat lightly and said with great bravado: "Fine then. Since you're being so sincere, I'll reluctantly agree."

Liang Shi immediately broke into a smile.

After the proposal, Liang Shi began preparing for the wedding.

Her explanation to everyone was that because the previous wedding had been too simple, and neither set of parents had participated, they were having a proper one this time.

And also to let Zhaozao and Mumu participate.

This high-sounding excuse almost had Liang Shi herself convinced.

The truth was that she herself hadn't participated before either.

Liang Shi still decided to hold the wedding by the sea.

To let the ocean carry their longing and the celebration to those far away.

The wedding preparations went smoothly with the help of Zhao Xuning and Gu Yixue.

Zhao Xuning was in charge of setting up the venue, while Gu Yixue was in charge of filming on the wedding day.

Everyone was somewhat surprised when they learned Gu Yixue was responsible for this.

An internationally renowned director was actually filming something like this?

Gu Yixue shook her head helplessly: "Can't help it. Who told her she's the group's darling?"

"Great-Aunt." Zhaozao ran over after hearing this and asked: "Who's the group's darling? Me or Mumu?"

Gu Yixue: "...Both you and Mumu are."

Zhaozao stuck her tongue out at her: "Master of keeping balance?"⁴

Gu Yixue: "..."

Hearing this, Liang Shi laughed: "Major overturning scene."

"It's because your daughter is so clever and mischievous—she can't be fooled even at such a young age." Gu Yixue scoffed. "But Mumu is very well-behaved. She only likes to eat."

Liang Shi: "..."

Mumu, who was sneaking food at the wedding venue, immediately swallowed the cookie in her mouth. "Great-Aunt, I wasn't sneaking food."

Gu Yixue glanced at her and reached out to brush away the cookie crumbs from the corner of her mouth. "Little darling, remember to destroy the evidence, okay?"

Looking at her two daughters running around at the wedding venue, Liang Shi felt happiness overflowing.

Footnotes:

¹ The names Sheng Yan (盛妍) and Shen Xuan (沈暄) use the characters from the name Zhu Mingqi originally wanted to give Liang Shi—Shen Xuanyan (沈暄妍). "Xuan" (暄) means warm/bright like sunshine, and "Yan" (妍) means beautiful/elegant. By splitting the name between the twins, each child carries part of the name meant for their mother.

² Zhaozao (朝朝) and Mumu (暮暮) - These nicknames literally mean "morning morning" and "evening evening." Together they form the phrase "朝朝暮暮" (zhāo zhāo mù mù), meaning "every morning and every evening" or "day and night."

³ This is a famous line from the Song Dynasty poem "Immortal at the Magpie Bridge" (鵲橋仙) by Qin Guan. The full couplet is: "If love between two hearts is long, why must they be together morning and night?" (兩情若是久長時，又豈在朝朝暮暮). It's traditionally about long-distance love enduring through separation. However, the author flips the sentiment—while the poem suggests true love doesn't need constant togetherness, the response argues that being together every day is what makes love truly wonderful.

⁴ "Master of keeping balance" (端水大師) - Internet slang referring to someone who tries to treat multiple parties equally/fairly without showing favoritism, like carefully carrying a bowl of water without spilling (端水). Zhaozao is cheekily calling out Gu Yixue for giving a diplomatic answer that doesn't pick a favorite.

Chapter 177-17

On the wedding day, both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu woke up very early. The two did their makeup together and styled their hair together, quite like they were about to attend a major fashion show.

Xu Qingzhu's styling was slightly more complicated than Liang Shi's, but the difference was only a few minutes.

Many people came to the wedding.

Lu Jiayi and the pregnant Fu You came all the way from the Capital.

Liang Xinzhou and his wife were walking around with children from both families.

Liang Xinhe and Sun Meirou were coaxing their little daughter. Ling Dang was searching all over the venue for Rainbow and Sheng Yu.

Rainbow hadn't been able to come back, while Sheng Yu was being held so tightly by Xu Qingya that she could barely breathe.

Liang Wanwan sat in a corner, her gaze involuntarily drifting to another place.

Zhou Yi'an and Su Meiqi were still bickering in a corner—or more accurately, Zhou Yi'an was bullying Su Meiqi as usual.

Chen Mian stayed alone in a corner.

Gu Xingyue and Feng Xian sat together, with a young girl sitting beside them. It was someone Gu Xingyue had picked up on the roadside before. She said she had lost her memory, but after coming here, Shen Hui recognized her—she was Yan Lin's younger sister, Yan Xi.

Shen Hui even called Yan Lin to come get her, but Yan Xi clung to Gu Xingyue's arm and absolutely refused to let go.

Yan Lin was helpless and could only ask Gu Xingyue to look after this troublesome sister of hers.

Sally and Lin Luoxi were still arguing over small things, but would make up again within two minutes.

Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui had already had their wedding last year, and Shen Hui's baby had already passed the one-month mark.

Zhao Ying and Yang Shuyan had directly announced their relationship at Zhao Xuning's wedding last year, crashing the internet.

As for Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe, they were the most mysterious. The two seemed to have chemistry, yet also seemed very distant.

Shen Siyan had already graduated and started working at the company to help Shen Fenghe, which also gave Shen Fenghe more free time.

Xu Qingya had promised not to cry before her sister's wedding, but as soon as the wedding started, she was holding Sheng Yu and crying like a three-year-old child.

Zhaozao and Mumu served as flower girls, scattering flowers the entire time as Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi walked in, having the time of their lives.

The seats below were full of guests, but on the stage there were only the two of them.

Liang Shi's eyes held only Xu Qingzhu, along with love that was about to overflow.

The same was true for Xu Qingzhu.

The officiant spoke: "Miss Liang Shi, do you take Miss Xu Qingzhu to enter into the hall of marriage, to be faithful to her and love her for life, through poverty and wealth, through sickness and health, until death?"

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu, a smile at the corners of her lips, her voice trembling: "I do."

"Miss Xu Qingzhu, do you take Miss Liang Shi to enter into the hall of marriage, to be faithful to her and love her for life, through poverty and wealth, through sickness and health, until death?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, took a gentle step forward to be closer to Liang Shi, and answered as calmly as she could: "I do."

"Now, will the newlyweds please kiss."

The crowd below erupted.

Liang Shi stepped forward, tilted her head, and leaned in to kiss Xu Qingzhu on the lips.

They had clearly kissed many times before, yet each time still felt like the first, making hearts race.

【Ding dong! Congratulations to the host on getting married. At the same time, I have good news to announce: the original host's trial results are out. All her crimes and memories have been erased, and she has been sent to Earth.】

On the evening of the wedding, before taking a shower, Liang Shi suddenly heard the system's mechanical voice.

When good things happen, one's spirits are lifted. For once, Liang Shi didn't find it annoying.

"Can I take a look?" Liang Shi had been plied with a lot of alcohol, and her tone was somewhat hazy.

The system projected an image into her mind. The person with the exact same face as hers was surrounded by a group of children, playing games with them. She looked very happy.

Watching this, Liang Shi sighed with emotion: "I'm really happy for her."

The system continued: 【The space-time gate has been repaired. Sun Chengcheng's memories have been erased and she has been sent back to Earth.】

"Huh? Why?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【She originally came here because of your influence. Now that the cause and effect have been resolved, it naturally had to be this way.】

Liang Shi suddenly negotiated with it: "The space-time gate is open? Then can Chen Mian go find Qi Jiao?"

System: 【? Outrageous!】

Liang Shi asked: "Didn't you say having an obsession was enough? Isn't Chen Mian's obsession deep enough?"

System: 【...】

The system's mechanical voice answered: 【Their wishes will naturally be heard by the gods.】

At the same time, Chen Mian, who had drunk herself into a stupor, suddenly heard a voice:

【Detection complete. You have an unresolved obsession in your body. The Obsession Management Bureau is activated. Do you wish to resolve your obsession? If you choose yes, your glands will be removed and you will be transported to the world where Qi Jiao is. If you choose no, this memory will be erased.】

Chen Mian hesitated: "Qi Jiao is still alive?"

Mechanical voice: 【Yes, she lives in another time and space.】

Chen Mian opened her eyes and looked at this world. She saw Liang Wanwan, who was looking at her. For the first time, she smiled at Liang Wanwan, then waved at her: "Wanwan, forget about me. I'm not worth it."

Chen Mian was a materialist. Because of Qi Jiao, she believed in these unfounded things for the first time.

She said firmly: "Send me there. Resolve the obsession."

Mechanical voice: 【Then you'll need to do good deeds and accumulate one hundred years' worth of kindness points.】

A flash of white light passed, and Chen Mian lost consciousness.

When she woke up, she found herself lying at the entrance of a flower shop—the same flower shop she had once seen in her dreams. It was called "Sleepless Deep Sea."¹

She immediately stood up. It was morning, and all the shops hadn't opened yet.

Chen Mian stood at the entrance of the flower shop for less than five minutes when that figure appeared before her eyes.

Probably startled by her strange gaze, Qi Jiao was fishing keys out of her bag while asking:
"Miss, are you here to buy flowers?"

Chen Mian stared at her, her eyes turning red.

Footnotes:

¹ "Sleepless Deep Sea" (深海未眠) - The flower shop's name is a poetic reference that connects to Chen Mian's name. "Mian" (眠) in Chen Mian's name means "sleep," so "未眠" (not sleeping/sleepless) creates a wordplay. The name suggests someone waiting sleeplessly in the depths, which mirrors Chen Mian's years of longing for Qi Jiao.

Chapter 177-18

"I'd like a lily." Chen Mian said as she handed over her phone. "And your contact information."

Qi Jiao: "?"

She should have refused, but as if possessed, Qi Jiao entered her number.

When she saw Chen Mian's tears fall, she herself shed a tear as well.

Qi Jiao opened the door to the flower shop and asked her: "What's your name?"

Chen Mian paused briefly, then smiled in the morning sunlight: "Chen Mian."

The bookstore next door had just opened, and the song playing was "Flock of Lonely Birds."¹

Zhou Yi'an had drunk herself into a stupor. Su Meiqi helped her back to the room, then was so exhausted she lay on the floor unable to move. She simply lay on the carpet playing with her phone.

Before long, a mechanical voice suddenly rang in Zhou Yi'an's mind: 【Detection complete. You have an unresolved obsession in your body. The Obsession Management Bureau is activated. Do you wish to resolve your obsession? If you choose yes, you will be transported to another time and space to see the person you've always wanted to see. If you choose no, this memory will be erased.】

Zhou Yi'an was startled: "The person I've always wanted to see?"

Mechanical voice: 【Liang Shi.】

Zhou Yi'an asked: "Is she doing well now?"

Mechanical voice: 【Alive.】

Zhou Yi'an closed her eyes: "Can I see her?"

The mechanical voice thought for a moment. 【You can be given five minutes to go to that time and space. Within five minutes, you must make a choice. Otherwise, the space-time gate will close, and it will be assumed you want to stay in that time and space.】

Zhou Yi'an nodded: "Okay."

Then a flash of white light, and Zhou Yi'an appeared at the entrance of a kindergarten.

All around were parents dropping off their children for school. Zhou Yi'an standing there looked somewhat out of place.

The person with the exact same face as Liang Shi was standing at the kindergarten entrance, smiling and saying good morning to each child.

Very energetic.

Those eyes held no hostility, yet it was easy to recognize her as the Liang Shi she knew.

Zhou Yi'an stood in a corner watching her the whole time. After all the children had gone in, she also noticed Zhou Yi'an at the entrance. They gazed at each other from a distance.

She curved her lips into a light smile, as if taking Zhou Yi'an back many years.

"Do you know me?" She took the initiative to walk over and ask.

Zhou Yi'an nodded: "I think so."

Liang Shi frowned: "And then?"

Zhou Yi'an pressed her lips together: "Are you dating anyone?"

Liang Shi was taken aback: "Are you trying to date me?"

"No." Zhou Yi'an said. "I was just asking."

Time kept passing. Before the space-time gate closed, Zhou Yi'an suddenly heard a shrill cry: "Zhou Yi'an!"

Su Meiqi was crying again.

Zhou Yi'an stared at Liang Shi for a while, then waved at her. "Be a good person from now on. I'm leaving."

In the final choice, Zhou Yi'an chose to return to the original world.

But the Obsession Management Bureau didn't delete her memories—they only took away her obsession.

When Zhou Yi'an woke up, she found Su Meiqi hugging her and crying, tears falling onto her face again.

Zhou Yi'an wiped her face. "What are you wailing about?"

Su Meiqi was startled and immediately jumped up, dropping her head on the floor again: "I thought you were dead."

Zhou Yi'an's head took a critical hit. She slowly sat up, holding her head: "Even if I wasn't dead, you'd have killed me from the fall."

"You just fell off the bed and didn't react at all." Su Meiqi was scared to death.

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Don't cry over nothing." Zhou Yi'an said. "It's too ugly."

Su Meiqi kicked her. "Do you even know how to talk?"

Zhou Yi'an leaned against the bed, thinking about the person she had just seen. What did she choose in the end?

She still chose this side.

Zhou Yi'an looked up at Su Meiqi—still that lively, bouncy little girl.

She gently closed her eyes, listening to Su Meiqi chattering in her ear.

She didn't find it annoying.

It seemed to have started when she was a teenager.

But what was Zhou Yi'an doing back then?

She seemed to have been thinking about how to destroy the world.

If there was someone who could be like her, that would have been more than she could ask for.

But now, Zhou Yi'an seemed to want to be a good person.

She couldn't quite say whether it was better to destroy the world with someone or to be a good person for someone.

But... she had already made her choice.

"Zhou Yi'an, are you even listening to me?" Su Meiqi shook her arm.

Zhou Yi'an opened her eyes carelessly. "Not even calling me 'jie' anymore?"

"I'm not calling you that. Zhou Yi'an, Zhou Yi'an." Su Meiqi continued to fool around.

Zhou Yi'an climbed onto the bed. "Suit yourself."

After Liang Shi finished washing up and returned to the room, she found Xu Qingzhu lying over the table writing something. When she went over, Xu Qingzhu suddenly put it away.

Liang Shi asked while drying her hair: "What are you writing?"

"A secret." Xu Qingzhu said as she tossed the card into a drawer, then went to blow-dry her hair. As she left, she reminded her: "No peeking."

Liang Shi glanced at her retreating figure. After she finished her skincare routine sitting there, she still didn't open the drawer to look.

After a while, when Xu Qingzhu came back, Liang Shi finally said: "Did you see Chen Mian tonight?"

"Chen Mian? Who's that?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "?"

Afterward, Liang Shi asked Zhao Xuning and Gu Yixue on her phone. None of them remembered Chen Mian.

Chen Mian had disappeared from this world, but in another world, she had met her beloved.

Here, only Liang Shi still remembered Chen Mian.

But that was also a good thing.

In the end, Liang Shi couldn't resist. While Xu Qingzhu went to the bathroom, she secretly took out that card.

What Xu Qingzhu had written on it was for her.

Liang Shi, this world is cruel, but you are wonderful.

You deserve to be loved by everyone.

Baby, happy wedding.

I love you.

After reading it, Liang Shi felt her heart swell with bittersweet emotion. Happiness was about to overflow. When Xu Qingzhu came out of the bathroom, she immediately went over and hugged her like a koala.

"What?" Xu Qingzhu pushed her.

Liang Shi waved the card in her hand, then leaned in to kiss her: "Wife, I love you too."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly and responded with feigned indifference: "Oh."

Outside was the sound of waves crashing against the shore, the lighthouse in the distance over the sea, the city with its towering buildings, the world woven of light and shadow.

And lights turning on one by one.

In this vast city, there was always one light shining for Liang Shi.

If happiness lay ahead like the lights of countless homes, then all the hardships along the way had meaning.

The End.

Footnotes:

¹ "Flock of Lonely Birds" (孤鳥症群) - This appears to be the title of a song playing in the scene. The title evokes imagery of lonely birds finding their flock, symbolically reflecting Chen Mian finally finding Qi Jiao after all this time.